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Remarried at 60

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Introduction: The Second "I Do"

I have not been where you are.

But I have been close. I have been the friend who got the late-night call. I have been the brother who got the long email. I have been the quiet one in the corner at the small wedding, watching two people in their sixties say "I do" for the second time — knowing the weight of that word was different than the first time.

The first time you said "I do," you were young. You were hopeful. You were full of the future. The first time you said "I do," you did not know what the marriage would cost. You did not know what the years would take. You did not know that one of you might be standing alone in the kitchen one morning, holding the other one's mug, and wondering what comes next.

The second time you say "I do," you know.

You know the cost. You have paid it. You know the years. You have lived them. You know that one of you might be standing alone in the kitchen one morning — because you have already been that person. You have already done that morning. You have already grieved that mug.

And you are saying "I do" anyway.

This book is for the person who is saying "I do" anyway. The person who has lost a spouse, or divorced after decades, or finally walked away from a marriage that had been over for years — and is now considering starting over at 50, 60, 70. The person who is looking at the second half of their life and asking the question: is there another chapter of marriage for me?

The answer is yes. But the answer is not the simple yes of the first time. The answer is the complex yes of the second time. The complex yes of someone who has been married before, who has been hurt before, who has learned before — and is willing to learn again. The complex yes of someone who knows that love is not just feeling. Love is also work. And the work is the part that matters.

This book is also for the person who is not yet sure. The person who is on the fence. The person who has been dating for a year, or two years, or five years — and still hasn't said "I do." The person who is wondering: is this really the right thing? Is this really the right person? Am I really ready to do this again?

This book will not tell you whether to remarry. This book will not tell you whether the person you are with is "the one." This book will not give you a checklist that ends with "yes, you should get married." That decision is yours. The decision is the most important decision you will make in the second half of your life. The decision deserves more than a checklist. The decision deserves a framework.

The framework in this book is built on four phases. The four phases are the way most 50+ couples move through the decision to remarry. The four phases are not a sequence you follow. The four phases are a map of the territory — so you know what you are walking into. The four phases are:

- The Decision — should I remarry?
- The Courtship — the dating, the ex-spouses, the adult children, the practical
- The Blending — the wedding, the family, the finances, the new life

- The New Marriage — the daily life, the new normal, the long game

Each phase has its own challenges. Each phase has its own questions. Each phase has its own work. The work is not the same as the first time. The work is deeper. The work is harder. The work is also more meaningful — because the second time, you are not hoping. The second time, you are choosing.

I have written this book because I have seen the second marriages that work. I have also seen the second marriages that fail. The difference is not love. The difference is not compatibility. The difference is the work. The difference is whether the couple does the work of the four phases, or skips them. The difference is whether the couple builds the foundation, or assumes the foundation is there.

I have written this book for the couple who is willing to do the work. I have written this book for the couple who is willing to build the foundation. I have written this book for the couple who is willing to say "I do" the second time — knowing what it means, knowing what it costs, knowing what it gives.

You are not alone. There are millions of people in the second half of life who are considering, navigating, or living the second marriage. The second marriage is one of the most common life stages in the modern world. The second marriage is also one of the least discussed. The second marriage is the life stage no one writes about. The second marriage is the life stage that gets a joke at the family dinner and a sigh at the therapist's office. The second marriage is the life stage that is full of hope and full of complication. The second marriage is real.

I want to be careful with you. I want to be useful without being preachy, honest without being grim. I want to be the friend who has seen a few of these marriages through, who knows the things that matter and the things that don't, who can tell you what people wish they had done and what they wish they hadn't.

I want to be the friend who says: you are not failing.

Whatever you are doing right now — whatever you are not doing — you are not failing. The decision to remarry is one of the hardest decisions you will make. The decision deserves your time. The decision deserves your honesty. The decision deserves the work.

If you are reading this book, you are doing the work. That is enough.

Let us begin.

Part I: The Decision

Chapter 1: The Question You Are Not Asking Out Loud

There is a question. The question is in your head, in the back of your mind, in the quiet moments when no one else is around. The question is in the kitchen at 11 pm when you are doing the dishes alone. The question is in the car on the long drive when the radio is off. The question is in the bed at 3 am when the ceiling is the only thing that will look back at you.

The question is: should I remarry?

The question is not the same as "do I love this person." You may already know the answer to that. The question is also not the same as "does this person love me." You may already know the answer to that too. The question is bigger than the two of you. The question includes the children. The question includes the ex-spouses. The question includes the money. The question includes the friends. The question includes the future. The question includes the past.

The question is whether the second marriage is the right thing for you. The question is whether the second marriage is the right thing for the other person. The question is whether the second marriage is the right thing for the people around you. The question is whether the second marriage is the right thing for the years you have left.

The question is the most important question of the second half of your life. The question deserves more than a casual answer. The question deserves more than a hopeful answer. The question deserves the work.

This chapter is about the question. This chapter is about the work. This chapter is about how to think about the question — not the answer, but the question itself. The question is the work. The answer is the next step. The next step cannot be made well unless the question is thought through well.

Chapter at a Glance

- The 5 Questions to Ask Yourself Before You Say "I Do" Again
- The 5 Things to Be Honest About (That Couples Often Hide)
- The 4 Reasons Couples Choose to Remarry (And Which One Is Yours)
- The Scorecard: Are You Ready to Decide?
- Key Terms: Remarriage, Blended Family, Pre-nup, Cohabitation
- Reflection Questions for the Two of You
- Action for This Week: The Honest Conversation

The 5 Questions to Ask Yourself Before You Say "I Do" Again

The question of whether to remarry is a personal question. The answer is yours. But the answer is better when the question is thought through. The thinking is the work. The 5 questions in this section are the questions that 50+ couples need to answer before they can answer the big one.

1. "Am I ready to be married, or am I ready to not be alone?"

The question is hard. The question is honest. The question is the difference between remarrying for the right reason and remarrying for the wrong reason.

Remarrying for the right reason is wanting the second marriage. Remarrying for the wrong reason is wanting to not be alone. The two reasons feel the same in the moment. The two reasons are not the same in the long run. Remarrying for the right reason is choosing the person. Remarrying for the wrong reason is choosing the relationship status.

The difference shows up in the second year of the marriage. The difference shows up when the newness wears off. The difference shows up when the new person is not new anymore. The difference shows up when the loneliness that the marriage was supposed to fix comes back, in a different form, after the wedding.

If you are remarrying because you are ready to be married to this person, in the way that the first marriage was real, with the same work and the same commitment — then the reason is the right reason. If you are remarrying because you cannot stand another Saturday night alone, or another holiday without a partner, or another year without someone to hold — then the reason may be the wrong reason. The reason can be changed. The reason is the work.

2. "Have I grieved the first marriage, or am I still grieving it?"

The grief of the first marriage is real. The grief is not just for the spouse who died. The grief is also for the marriage that ended in divorce. The grief is for the life you thought you would have. The grief is for the future that didn't happen. The grief is for the version of yourself that was married to the first person.

The grief needs to be done before the second marriage can start. The grief is the work. The grief is the foundation.

If the grief is not done, the second marriage will carry it. The second marriage will carry the grief of the first marriage. The second marriage will carry the unfinished conversations. The second marriage will carry the unhealed wounds. The second marriage will carry the ghost of the first marriage — and the ghost will be in the room with you, every day, for the rest of your life.

If the grief is done — if you have walked through the grief, if you have felt the grief, if you have let the grief change you — then the second marriage starts on solid ground. If the grief is not done, the second marriage starts on the grave of the first marriage. The grave is not a foundation. The grave is a hole.

3. "Do I know who this person is, or do I know who I want this person to be?"

The first marriage often starts with a fantasy. The fantasy is who you think the person is. The fantasy is who you want the person to be. The fantasy is the best version of the person, the version that does not exist yet, the version you are going to create together.

The second marriage cannot afford the fantasy. The second marriage has to start with the real person. The real person has flaws. The real person has habits. The real person has the way they load the dishwasher wrong, the way they snore at night, the way they handle stress, the way they handle money, the way they handle their ex, the way they handle their children. The real person is the whole person. The real person is the person you are committing to.

If you know the real person, the second marriage can start. If you know the fantasy, the second marriage will crash. The crash is not the second marriage's fault. The crash is the fantasy's fault. The fantasy

always crashes. The real person survives.

4. "What does this marriage cost, and am I willing to pay?"

The second marriage has a cost. The cost is not just the wedding. The cost is the financial blending — the house, the retirement, the inheritance, the pre-nup, the will. The cost is the family blending — the adult children, the grandchildren, the holidays, the in-laws, the ex-spouses. The cost is the time — the time you have to give to the new marriage, the time you have left for yourself, the time you have left for your friends, the time you have left for the people who are no longer in your life because the second marriage takes the time.

The cost is real. The cost is not a reason not to remarry. The cost is a reason to know what you are signing up for. The cost is the work.

If you are willing to pay the cost — and the cost is not just the money, the cost is the time, the cost is the family, the cost is the parts of your old life that have to change — then the second marriage is possible. If you are not willing to pay the cost, the second marriage will fail. The failure is not a verdict on the second marriage. The failure is a verdict on the cost. The cost was too high. The marriage could not pay.

5. "What am I afraid of?"

The fear of the second marriage is the most honest question. The fear is real. The fear is not a reason not to remarry. The fear is the way the second marriage shows you what you have not yet healed. The fear is the way the second marriage asks you to grow.

Common fears:

- Fear of losing the first marriage's memory. The fear is real. The memory is not lost. The memory is honored. The second marriage does not erase the first marriage. The second marriage adds to the first marriage. The first marriage is part of the story. The second marriage is the next chapter.

- Fear of being hurt again. The fear is real. The hurt is not guaranteed. The second marriage can be the marriage where you are not hurt. The second marriage can be the marriage where the hurt is replaced by the work.

- Fear of what the children will think. The fear is real. The children are not you. The children have their own fears. The children's fears are not the couple's fears. The children's fears are part of the children. The couple's fears are the couple's work.

- Fear of getting it wrong again. The fear is real. The getting-it-wrong is the past. The getting-it-wrong is the first marriage. The second marriage is a new start. The second marriage is a new chance. The second marriage is the chance to get it right.

The fears are real. The fears are not the answer. The answer is what you do with the fears. The answer is the work.

The 5 Things to Be Honest About (That Couples Often Hide)

The honesty of the second marriage is the foundation. The honesty of the second marriage is the work. The 5 things in this section are the things that couples in the second marriage often hide — from each other, from the family, from themselves. The hiding is the enemy of the second marriage. The honesty is the friend of the second marriage.

1. The Money. The money is the most common thing couples hide. The hiding is the easiest to do. The hiding is the hardest to undo. The hiding is the reason the second marriage ends in the second year.

The money hides:

- "I have more debt than I told you."
- "I have less retirement than I told you."
- "I have an inheritance I didn't tell you about."
- "I am still financially entangled with my ex."
- "I will not share my money with you."
- "I expect you to share your money with me."

The money is real. The money is part of the second marriage. The money needs to be on the table before the wedding. The money is the work.

2. The Ex. The ex is the second most common thing couples hide. The ex is the past. The ex is also the present — especially if there are children. The ex needs to be talked about. The ex needs to be honest about.

The ex hides:

- "My ex and I are still in contact more than I told you."

- "My ex and I argue more than I told you."
- "My ex is not over the divorce."
- "My ex will be in the picture for the rest of my life because of the children."
- "My ex has opinions about you."

The ex is the work. The ex is the reality of the second marriage. The ex is not a reason not to remarry. The ex is a reason to be honest.

3. The Children. The children are the most common source of unexpected conflict. The children are also the most important. The children are the reason the second marriage is harder than the first marriage.

The children hides:

- "My children are not on board with the remarriage."
- "My children have expectations about my money that I didn't tell you about."
- "My children have relationships with my ex that I didn't tell you about."
- "My children are not ready for me to have a new partner."

The children are the work. The children are the reality. The children need to be part of the decision, not just told about the decision.

4. The Health. The health is the most important thing couples hide. The hiding is the easiest to do. The hiding is the most damaging. The hiding is the reason the second marriage ends in crisis.

The health hides:

- "I have a health condition I didn't tell you about."
- "I am on medication that I didn't tell you about."

- "I have a family history of [X] that I didn't tell you about."
- "I have concerns about my future health that I didn't tell you about."

The health is the work. The health is the foundation. The health needs to be on the table.

5. The Expectations. The expectations are the most common cause of disappointment. The expectations are also the most preventable. The expectations are the work.

The expectations hides:

- "I expect you to be different from my ex."
- "I expect the second marriage to be easier than the first."
- "I expect you to take on a role that my ex used to do."
- "I expect the children to love you the way my ex's children did."

The expectations are the work. The expectations are the reality check. The expectations need to be named before the wedding.

The 4 Reasons Couples Choose to Remarry (And Which One Is Yours)

The reason for the second marriage is the most important predictor of the second marriage's success. The reason is not the only predictor. The reason is the foundation. The 4 reasons in this section are the 4 most common reasons couples in their 50s and 60s choose to remarry. The reason that is yours may be more than one. The reason that is yours may be a blend. The reason that is yours is yours to name.

Reason 1: Companionship. "I love this person. I want to spend my years with this person. I do not want to grow old alone. I want a partner. I want a friend. I want a person who knows me and loves me and is there at the end of the day."

Companionship is the most common reason. Companionship is also the most sustainable reason. Companionship is not just about not being alone. Companionship is about being with someone. Companionship is about the morning coffee and the evening walk. Companionship is about the inside jokes and the shared memories. Companionship is about the years.

If your reason is companionship, the second marriage is likely to work. Companionship is the foundation. Companionship is the work. Companionship is the gift.

Reason 2: Practical. "We are already living together. We are already sharing the house, the bills, the car, the dog, the kitchen. The marriage is just the legal paperwork for what is already real. The marriage is the next step."

The practical reason is real. The practical reason is also the most common reason the second marriage fails. The practical reason is the foundation of convenience, not the foundation of love. The foundation of convenience is the foundation that does not survive the first big fight.

If your reason is practical, the second marriage may or may not work. The practical reason is not enough. The practical reason is the supplement, not the foundation. The foundation is the love. The love is the work.

Reason 3: Family. "I want my grandchildren to have a grandpa. I want my children to have a step-parent. I

want my family to be whole again. I want the family that was taken from me by the death/divorce. I want the family back."

The family reason is the most painful reason. The family reason is also the most dangerous reason. The family reason is the reason that does not honor the new marriage. The family reason is the reason that makes the new marriage a vehicle for the old family. The new marriage is not a vehicle. The new marriage is a marriage. The new marriage is two people. The two people are the foundation. The children are not the foundation. The grandchildren are not the foundation. The two people are the foundation.

If your reason is family, the second marriage is at risk. The family reason is not enough. The family reason is the supplement, not the foundation. The foundation is the love of the two people. The love is the work.

Reason 4: Love. "I love this person. I cannot imagine my life without this person. I want to be married to this person. I want to grow old with this person. I want this person in my life for the rest of my life."

Love is the rarest reason. Love is also the strongest reason. Love is the reason that survives the second year, the fifth year, the tenth year. Love is not just a feeling. Love is a choice. Love is the daily choice. Love is the work.

If your reason is love, the second marriage is most likely to work. Love is the foundation. Love is the work. Love is the gift. Love is the most important thing in the second marriage. Love is also the most fragile. Love needs to be tended. Love needs to be protected. Love needs the work.

The Scorecard: Are You Ready to Decide?

The decision to remarry is the most important decision. The decision is better when the question is thought through. The scorecard is a way to think through the question. The scorecard is not a verdict. The scorecard is a mirror. The scorecard is a way to see the readiness.

| Question | Score (1-5) |

|---|---|

| I have grieved my first marriage, or my first spouse, fully | /5 |

| I know the real person, not the fantasy | /5 |

| I am willing to pay the cost of the second marriage | /5 |

| I have been honest with my partner about money | /5 |

| I have been honest with my partner about the ex | /5 |

| I have been honest with my partner about the children | /5 |

| I have been honest with my partner about health | /5 |

| I have named the expectations I have for the second marriage | /5 |

| I know why I want to remarry, and the reason is real | /5 |

| I have asked the people I trust what they think, and I have listened | /5 |

Total: /50

Interpreting your score:

- 40-50: You are ready to decide. The decision may be "yes" or "no" — but the question is thought through.
- 30-39: You are getting close. There are still some things to think through. The remaining chapters will help.
- 20-29: You are not ready. There is still work to do. The work is the question.
- Under 20: You are not ready. The decision is being driven by something other than the real readiness. The work is to slow down.

Key Terms

- Remarriage: A marriage after a previous marriage ended (by death or divorce)
- Blended Family: A family that includes children from previous relationships
- Pre-nup (Pre-nuptial Agreement): A legal agreement about money and property in case of divorce
- Cohabitation: Living together without being married
- Step-family: A family where one or both partners have children from a previous relationship

Reflection Questions for the Two of You

1. What is one thing you are most afraid of about the second marriage?
2. What is one thing you most hope for in the second marriage?

3. What is one thing from the first marriage that you would do differently?
4. What is one thing from the first marriage that you would keep?
5. What is one thing the children need to know before the wedding?
6. What is one thing the ex needs to know before the wedding?

Action for This Week: The Honest Conversation

Within the next 7 days, do these 5 things:

1. Have the honest conversation about money. Both of you. With the actual numbers. The income. The debt. The retirement. The inheritance. The expectations.
2. Have the honest conversation about the ex. The contact. The arguments. The role. The reality.
3. Have the honest conversation about the children. Their feelings. Their expectations. Their relationships with the ex. Their relationships with the new partner.
4. Have the honest conversation about health. The conditions. The medications. The family history. The future.
5. Have the honest conversation about expectations. What you want. What you do not want. What you are willing to give. What you are not willing to give.

The conversations are the work. The work is the question. The question is the foundation.

A Closing Word

The question of whether to remarry is the most important question. The question deserves the work. The question deserves the honesty. The question deserves the time.

The next chapters will help you think through the question. The next chapters will help you navigate the second marriage. The next chapters will help you do the work of the four phases.

You are not failing. You are asking the question. The question is the work.

The work is the question.

Chapter 2: The First Decision — Should This Be Marriage?

The first decision of the second marriage is not "should I marry this person." The first decision is "should this be marriage at all." The question sounds simple. The question is not simple. The question is the most important question of the second half of your life.

In the first marriage, the question was a given. The first marriage was expected. The first marriage was the path. The first marriage was what everyone around you was doing. The first marriage did not need to be questioned. The first marriage just was.

In the second marriage, the question is not a given. The second marriage is a choice. The second marriage is a path you can take or not take. The second marriage is what you decide to do, with the years you have left. The second marriage is the choice. The choice is the work.

This chapter is about the choice. This chapter is about the question. This chapter is about how to think about whether the second marriage is the right thing — for you, for the other person, for the people around you, for the years you have.

Chapter at a Glance

- The 4 Lenses for the Decision (Personal, Relational, Family, Practical)
- The 3 Tests to Try Before the Wedding (Cohabitation, Travel, Stress)

- The 4 Questions to Ask the Children
- The 3 Conversations to Have with Your Ex (Yes, You Read That Right)
- The Scorecard: Are You Ready to Be Engaged?
- Key Terms: Engagement, Cohabitation Agreement, Pre-nup
- Reflection Questions for the Two of You
- Action for This Week: The Engagement Plan

The 4 Lenses for the Decision

The decision to remarry is a multi-lens decision. The decision cannot be made from one lens. The decision needs to be made from four lenses. The four lenses are the four ways of seeing the decision. The four lenses together give you the full picture. The four lenses are: personal, relational, family, practical.

Lens 1: Personal. The personal lens is the most important lens. The personal lens is the lens that asks: what is best for me? The personal lens is the lens that asks: am I doing this for the right reason? The personal lens is the lens that asks: am I ready?

The personal lens is hard because it requires honesty with yourself. The personal lens is hard because the honesty may show you that you are not ready. The personal lens is hard because the readiness is not just about wanting the marriage. The readiness is about being able to do the work of the marriage. The readiness is about being the person who can be married, not just the person who wants to be married.

The personal lens also requires honesty about the past. The personal lens requires the grief of the first marriage to be done. The personal lens requires the work of the healing to be done. The personal lens

requires the self to be the self that is ready for the second marriage, not the self that is still tangled with the first marriage.

The personal lens is the lens that asks the most important question: "What is right for me, in this season, with this person, in this time?"

Lens 2: Relational. The relational lens is the lens that asks: what is best for us? The relational lens is the lens that asks: are we the right people for each other? The relational lens is the lens that asks: can we do the work of the second marriage together?

The relational lens is the lens of compatibility. The compatibility is not just about liking the same things. The compatibility is about how the two of you handle conflict, handle money, handle stress, handle the family, handle the ex, handle the future. The compatibility is about the small daily things. The compatibility is about the way you argue. The compatibility is about the way you make up.

The relational lens is the lens that asks the second most important question: "Can we do this work, together, for the rest of our lives?"

Lens 3: Family. The family lens is the lens that asks: what is best for the people around us? The family lens is the lens that asks: how will the children respond? The family lens is the lens that asks: how will the ex respond? The family lens is the lens that asks: how will the friends respond? The family lens is the lens that asks: how will the new family fit together?

The family lens is the lens that is most often skipped. The family lens is the lens that causes the most problems when it is skipped. The family lens is the lens that catches the things the couple did not see.

The family lens requires conversations. The conversations are with the children, the ex, the friends, the family. The conversations are the work. The conversations are not optional. The conversations are the way the family lens is applied.

The family lens is the lens that asks the third most important question: "How will this marriage affect the people we love, and are we willing to do the work of those relationships?"

Lens 4: Practical. The practical lens is the lens that asks: what does this marriage look like in the day-to-day? The practical lens is the lens that asks: where do we live? The practical lens is the lens that asks: how do we handle the money? The practical lens is the lens that asks: what happens if one of us gets sick? The practical lens is the lens that asks: what happens if one of us dies?

The practical lens is the lens that catches the things the couple thought they would deal with later. The practical lens is the lens that prevents the most expensive mistakes. The practical lens is the lens that turns the dreamy "I do" into the grounded "I do."

The practical lens is not the most romantic lens. The practical lens is the most important lens for the long-term success of the marriage. The practical lens is the foundation of the second marriage. The practical lens is the work.

The practical lens is the lens that asks the fourth most important question: "What does this marriage look like in 5 years, in 10 years, in 20 years, and have we planned for that?"

The 3 Tests to Try Before the Wedding

The decision to remarry is a big decision. The decision is not made in a moment. The decision is made over time. The decision is tested in real life. The 3 tests in this section are the 3 ways to test the second marriage before the wedding. The tests are not guarantees. The tests are not perfect predictors. The tests are the best way to know if the second marriage will work, before the wedding, before the commitment, before the cost.

Test 1: Cohabitation. Live together for at least a year before the wedding. The cohabitation is the test of daily life. The cohabitation is the test of the small things. The cohabitation is the test of how you share the bathroom, the kitchen, the bed, the money, the in-laws, the holidays. The cohabitation is the test of how you handle the disagreement about the dishwasher. The cohabitation is the test of how you handle the morning routine. The cohabitation is the test of how you handle the weekend.

If you can live together for a year and still want to get married, the second marriage is more likely to work. If you can live together for a year and the daily life is good, the second marriage has a foundation. The cohabitation is the test of the foundation.

If you cannot live together for a year — if the daily life is hard, if the small things are big fights, if the cohabitation feels like a job — the second marriage will be that, multiplied by the wedding and the commitment. The second marriage will not fix the cohabitation problems. The second marriage will amplify them.

Test 2: Travel. Take a long trip together. At least two weeks. In a place neither of you has been. The travel is the test of the unknown. The travel is the test of how you handle the unplanned. The travel is the test of how you handle the stress of the airport, the hotel, the foreign food, the lost luggage, the missed train.

If you can travel together for two weeks and the trip was good, the second marriage is more likely to work. If you can travel together and you handled the unknown together, the second marriage has a foundation. The travel is the test of the foundation.

If you cannot travel together without fighting, the second marriage will not fix the travel problems. The second marriage will amplify them.

Test 3: Stress. Go through a real stress together before the wedding. A real stress is not the stress you create. A real stress is the stress that happens — the family crisis, the health scare, the job loss, the money crisis, the ex crisis. The real stress is the test of how you handle the hard things together.

If you can go through a real stress and come out the other side still wanting to be married, the second marriage is more likely to work. If the real stress made you closer, the second marriage has a foundation. The stress is the test of the foundation.

If the real stress broke you, the second marriage will not fix the stress problems. The second marriage will amplify them.

The 3 tests are not perfect. The 3 tests are not guarantees. The 3 tests are the best way to know if the second marriage will work, before the wedding.

The 4 Questions to Ask the Children

The children are part of the decision. The children are not the decision. The children are the people who will be most affected by the second marriage. The children need to be asked, listened to, and respected. The 4 questions in this section are the questions to ask the children. The questions are not the only questions. The questions are the starting point.

1. "How do you feel about me remarrying?"

The question is open. The question is honest. The question invites the children to share. The question is the way to find out if the children are on board, struggling, or somewhere in between.

The question is hard. The children may be honest. The honesty may be hard to hear. The children may say "I am not ready." The children may say "I am happy for you." The children may say "I do not know." All of these are real answers. All of these are honored answers. The answer is not the decision. The answer is the information. The information is the work.

2. "What are you most worried about?"

The question is the follow-up. The question is the way to get under the surface. The children often have unspoken worries. The unspoken worries are the ones that become problems.

Common unspoken worries:

- "I will be replaced."
- "My inheritance will be taken."
- "My mom/dad will be forgotten."
- "I will have to deal with a new step-parent."
- "The new marriage will change my relationship with you."

The worries are real. The worries deserve to be named. The naming is the work.

3. "What would help you feel okay about this?"

The question is the way to make the children part of the solution. The question is the way to honor the children's role. The question is the way to make the children feel heard.

The answers may surprise you. The answers may be small. The answers may be "I just want to be included in the wedding." The answers may be "I want to have a relationship with the new person at my own pace." The answers may be "I want to know that my inheritance is protected." The answers are the work.

4. "What questions do you have that I haven't asked?"

The question is the way to give the children permission to bring up the hard things. The question is the way to show that you want to know, not just that you want to tell. The question is the way to model the honesty.

The children may surprise you. The children may have been holding something for years. The children may finally say the thing that has been unsaid. The saying is the work.

The 3 Conversations to Have with Your Ex (Yes, You Read That Right)

The ex is part of the second marriage. The ex is the past. The ex is also the present. The ex is the person who shares the children with you. The ex is the person who will be in your life for the rest of your life, because of the children. The ex is the person who needs to be talked to, before the second marriage.

The 3 conversations in this section are the conversations to have with the ex. The conversations are not the only conversations. The conversations are the starting point.

Conversation 1: "I am remarrying. I wanted you to hear it from me first."

The conversation is the courtesy. The conversation is the way to honor the ex as the parent of your children. The conversation is the way to make the ex part of the news, not the last to know.

The ex may be happy. The ex may be sad. The ex may be angry. The ex may be indifferent. All of these are real responses. All of these are honored responses. The response is not the decision. The response is the information. The information is the work.

Conversation 2: "Here is how the children will be affected. Here is what I want to do to make this good for them."

The conversation is the parenting conversation. The conversation is the way to make the ex your partner in the parenting, even if you are no longer partners in the marriage. The conversation is the way to show the ex that the children are the priority.

The ex may agree. The ex may disagree. The ex may have their own ideas. The ideas are the work. The work is the children.

Conversation 3: "Here is how the money will be handled. Here is the pre-nup. Here is the will."

The conversation is the practical conversation. The conversation is the way to make the ex know that the money is not being taken from the children. The conversation is the way to make the pre-nup part of the conversation, not a surprise.

The ex may be reassured. The ex may be suspicious. The ex may want their own lawyer. The lawyers are the work. The work is the money.

The 3 conversations with the ex are the conversations that most couples skip. The 3 conversations are the conversations that prevent the most post-wedding conflict. The 3 conversations are the work.

The Scorecard: Are You Ready to Be Engaged?

The decision to be engaged is the next step. The decision to be engaged is the step that says: yes, the second marriage is the right thing. The decision to be engaged is the step that says: yes, we have done the work of the decision. The decision is the foundation. The scorecard is a way to see the readiness.

| Question | Score (1-5) |

|---|---|

| I have looked at the decision through all 4 lenses | /5 |

| I have done at least 1 of the 3 tests (cohabitation, travel, stress) | /5 |

| I have had the 4 conversations with the children | /5 |

| I have had the 3 conversations with the ex | /5 |

| I have asked the 5 questions in Chapter 1 | /5 |

| I have been honest with my partner about the 5 hidden things | /5 |

| I know the 4 reasons couples remarry, and I know mine | /5 |

| My partner and I have named the expectations | /5 |

| I have talked to at least 2 trusted friends about this |
/5 |

| I have given myself at least 6 months to think about
it | /5 |

Total: /50

Interpreting your score:

- 40-50: You are ready to be engaged. The engagement is the next step.
- 30-39: You are close. There are still some things to do.
- 20-29: You are not ready. There is more work.
- Under 20: You are not ready. The engagement would be premature.

Key Terms

- Engagement: The formal agreement to marry, before the wedding
- Cohabitation Agreement: A legal agreement for couples living together, often including money and property
- Pre-nup (Pre-nuptial Agreement): A legal agreement about money and property in case of divorce, signed before the marriage
- Will: A legal document about what happens to your money and property when you die
- Trustee: A person who manages money or property for someone else

Reflection Questions for the Two of You

1. What is one thing you have not yet talked about that you need to talk about?

2. What is one test you have not yet done that you should do?
3. What is one conversation with the children that you have been avoiding?
4. What is one conversation with the ex that you have been avoiding?
5. What is one expectation that you have not named?
6. What is one timeline question you have not yet asked?

Action for This Week: The Engagement Plan

Within the next 7 days, do these 5 things:

1. Decide which test to do first. Cohabitation, travel, or stress. Pick one. Plan it. Schedule it.
2. Have the 4 conversations with the children. Even if the children are adults. The conversations are the work.
3. Have the 3 conversations with the ex. Even if the ex is hard to talk to. The conversations are the work.
4. Schedule the engagement conversation. The two of you. The when. The how. The where.
5. Decide on the timeline. When do you want to be married? In 6 months? In a year? In 2 years? The timeline is the work.

The Engagement Plan is the foundation. The foundation is the work. The work is the second marriage.

A Closing Word

The decision to remarry is the most important decision. The decision deserves the work. The decision deserves the honesty. The decision deserves the time.

The 4 lenses, the 3 tests, the 4 questions for the children, the 3 conversations with the ex — these are the work. The work is the foundation. The foundation is the second marriage.

You are not failing. You are deciding. The deciding is the work.

The work is the deciding.

Chapter 3: The Grief That's Still in the Room

The grief of the first marriage is the most important thing in the second marriage. The grief is the part that the couple does not see. The grief is the part that the couple does not talk about. The grief is the part that the couple thinks is done. The grief is the part that is never done.

The grief is the first spouse. The grief is the first marriage. The grief is the life that was. The grief is the future that didn't happen. The grief is the version of you that was married to the first person. The grief is the house, the routines, the inside jokes, the holiday traditions, the way the first person made you laugh. The grief is all of it. The grief is the weight of the first marriage, carried into the second.

If the grief is not grieved, the grief will be in the second marriage. The grief will be in the bedroom. The grief will be at the dinner table. The grief will be in the way you fight. The grief will be in the way you make up. The grief will be in the way you make love. The grief will be in the way you look at the new person when the new person is not looking.

The grief is the work. The grief is the foundation. The grief is the way to honor the first marriage, by giving it the grief it deserves, before the second marriage begins.

Chapter at a Glance

- Why the First Marriage Must Be Grieved, Not Bypassed

- The 4 Kinds of Grief: Death, Divorce, Slow Loss, Unrealized Future
- The 6 Things Grief Does to the Second Marriage (If Not Worked)
- The 5 Ways to Finish the Grief Work
- The "Ghost Marriage" — Carrying the First One Into the Second
- Case Study: Ann & Tom (Ages 67/70)
- Scorecard: How Much of the Grief Is Still in the Room?
- Key Terms: Complicated Grief, Continuing Bonds, Grief Work
- Reflection Questions for the Two of You
- Action for This Week: The Grief Inventory

Why the First Marriage Must Be Grieved, Not Bypassed

The grief of the first marriage is not optional. The grief is the price of the first marriage. The grief is the cost of having loved someone for years. The grief is the cost of having built a life with someone. The grief is the cost of having lost that life, whether to death or to divorce.

The grief is not a sign of weakness. The grief is not a sign that the second marriage is wrong. The grief is a sign that the first marriage was real. The first marriage was a real marriage. The first marriage deserves real grief. The real grief is the work.

The grief cannot be bypassed. The grief cannot be skipped. The grief cannot be "moved past" by remarrying quickly. The grief cannot be "replaced" by the new marriage. The grief is not a person to be replaced. The grief is the love that was. The grief is

the love that is still there. The grief is the love that needs to be honored.

If the grief is bypassed, the grief comes back. The grief comes back in the middle of the second marriage, when the new person is not looking. The grief comes back in the middle of the second marriage, when the new person does something that reminds you of the first person. The grief comes back in the middle of the second marriage, when the new person is sick, or scared, or sad, or just being human. The grief comes back because the grief was not honored. The grief comes back because the grief is owed. The grief is the work.

The 4 Kinds of Grief: Death, Divorce, Slow Loss, Unrealized Future

The grief of the first marriage is not one kind of grief. The grief is four kinds. The four kinds are the four ways the first marriage ended. The four kinds require different kinds of grief work. The four kinds are:

Kind 1: Death. The grief of death is the grief of the spouse who is gone. The grief is the loss of the person. The grief is the loss of the future with the person. The grief is the loss of the daily life with the person. The grief is the loss of the love that was. The grief is the deepest grief. The grief takes the longest. The grief is the most personal.

The grief of death requires:

- Mourning the loss of the person
- Mourning the loss of the future
- Mourning the loss of the daily
- Honoring the love that was
- Continuing the love that is (in a different form)

- Allowing the new love, without abandoning the old love

Kind 2: Divorce. The grief of divorce is the grief of the marriage that ended. The grief is the loss of the partner. The grief is the loss of the future. The grief is the loss of the daily life. The grief is the loss of the love that was. The grief is complicated by the fact that the spouse is still alive. The grief is complicated by the fact that the marriage ended by choice. The grief is the most complex grief.

The grief of divorce requires:

- Mourning the loss of the marriage
- Mourning the loss of the partner
- Mourning the loss of the future
- Honoring the love that was (if there was love)
- Forgiving the partner (and yourself)
- Allowing the new love, without comparing to the old

Kind 3: Slow Loss. The grief of slow loss is the grief of the marriage that ended by inches. The marriage did not die. The marriage did not divorce. The marriage just slowly stopped being a marriage. The marriage became a roommate situation. The marriage became a business partnership. The marriage became a habit. The grief of slow loss is the grief of the marriage that died without anyone noticing. The grief is the most subtle grief. The grief is the most often unrecognized grief.

The grief of slow loss requires:

- Naming what was lost
- Mourning the marriage that was supposed to be
- Honoring the love that was (if there was love)
- Releasing the guilt of "letting it die"

- Allowing the new love, without expecting it to die the same way

Kind 4: Unrealized Future. The grief of unrealized future is the grief of the marriage that was supposed to happen. The marriage that did not happen. The marriage that was prevented by death, or by circumstance, or by the first marriage. The grief of unrealized future is the grief of the life that was supposed to be. The grief is the most abstract grief. The grief is the most existential grief.

The grief of unrealized future requires:

- Naming the future that was lost
- Mourning the life that was supposed to be
- Honoring the hope that was
- Releasing the future
- Allowing the new love, without resenting the old

The four kinds of grief are not mutually exclusive. The four kinds can coexist. The four kinds can be present at the same time. The four kinds are the work. The four kinds of grief require different kinds of grief work. The four kinds of grief are the work of the second marriage.

The 6 Things Grief Does to the Second Marriage (If Not Worked)

The grief, if not worked, does six things to the second marriage. The six things are the damage. The six things are the cost. The six things are the things that show up in the second marriage, sometimes years after the second marriage began.

1. The Comparison. "My first spouse used to do this differently." "My first spouse never said that." "My first spouse was better at this." The comparison is the

most common damage. The comparison is the way the grief shows up in the daily life. The comparison is the way the first marriage invades the second.

2. The Trigger. A song. A smell. A phrase. A way of doing something. The trigger is the way the grief shows up unexpectedly. The trigger is the way the first marriage ambushes the second. The trigger is the way the new person is reminded of the first marriage, even when the new person did not mean to remind.

3. The Guilt. "I shouldn't be happy." "I shouldn't be laughing." "I shouldn't be enjoying this." The guilt is the way the grief shows up as a punishment for the new happiness. The guilt is the way the first marriage punishes the second. The guilt is the way the new marriage is held hostage by the old.

4. The Withdrawal. "I'm not ready to talk about it." "I need a moment." "I don't want to think about it right now." The withdrawal is the way the grief shows up as a retreat. The withdrawal is the way the new marriage is held at arm's length. The withdrawal is the way the new person is held at arm's length.

5. The Anger. "You don't understand." "You can't know what it was like." "You weren't there." The anger is the way the grief shows up as a defense. The anger is the way the first marriage defends itself against the second. The anger is the way the grief fights the new marriage for the right to be remembered.

6. The Anniversary Effect. The anniversary of the death. The anniversary of the divorce. The birthday of the first spouse. The wedding anniversary of the first marriage. The anniversary effect is the way the grief shows up on the calendar. The anniversary effect is the way the first marriage returns, every year, on the dates that matter.

The six things are real. The six things are the cost of the unworked grief. The six things are the work. The six things are the work of the grief work.

The 5 Ways to Finish the Grief Work

The grief work is the work. The grief work is the way to honor the first marriage, by giving it the grief it deserves, before the second marriage begins. The 5 ways in this section are the 5 ways to do the grief work. The 5 ways are not the only ways. The 5 ways are the starting point.

Way 1: The Grief Therapy. The grief therapy is the professional help. The grief therapy is the therapist who specializes in grief. The grief therapy is the way to do the grief work with someone who knows how to do the grief work. The grief therapy is not a sign of weakness. The grief therapy is a sign of strength.

Way 2: The Grief Ritual. The grief ritual is the personal ritual. The grief ritual is the candle you light on the anniversary. The grief ritual is the letter you write to the first spouse and burn. The grief ritual is the visit to the grave. The grief ritual is the way to honor the first marriage, in a way that is yours.

Way 3: The Continuing Bonds. The continuing bonds is the way to keep the first marriage in your life, in a healthy way. The continuing bonds is the photo on the shelf. The continuing bonds is the story you tell. The continuing bonds is the way the first marriage is part of your story, without being a wall in front of the second.

Way 4: The Forgiveness Work. The forgiveness work is the work of forgiving the first spouse. The forgiveness work is the work of forgiving yourself. The forgiveness work is the work of forgiving the circumstances. The

forgiveness work is the work of releasing the anger and the guilt. The forgiveness work is the work of the second marriage.

Way 5: The New Beginning. The new beginning is the work of starting the second marriage as a new beginning. The new beginning is not the erasing of the first marriage. The new beginning is the honoring of the first marriage and the starting of the second. The new beginning is the new chapter, not the new book.

The 5 ways are the work. The 5 ways are not optional. The 5 ways are the foundation of the second marriage.

The "Ghost Marriage" — Carrying the First One Into the Second

The ghost marriage is the unworked grief in the form of a marriage. The ghost marriage is the first marriage, walking through the second marriage, unseen. The ghost marriage is the way the first marriage takes up space in the second marriage, without the couple realizing it.

The ghost marriage shows up as:

- The habits of the first marriage, in the second
- The expectations from the first marriage, in the second
- The fights from the first marriage, in the second
- The intimacy of the first marriage, in the second
- The communication of the first marriage, in the second
- The roles from the first marriage, in the second

The ghost marriage is not the second marriage's fault. The ghost marriage is the first marriage's work, unfinished. The ghost marriage is the work of the

second marriage. The work is to name the ghost. The work is to honor the ghost. The work is to release the ghost, so the second marriage can be the second marriage, not the ghost of the first.

The way to deal with the ghost marriage is to name it. The way to deal with the ghost marriage is to talk about it. The way to deal with the ghost marriage is to let the new person know what the ghost is, and to ask the new person to help. The new person is not the enemy of the ghost. The new person is the partner in the work of releasing the ghost.

The ghost marriage is the work. The work is the ghost marriage. The work is the second marriage.

Case Study: Ann & Tom (Ages 67/70)

Ann was 67. Tom was 70. They had been married for 41 years. Ann was a retired nurse. Tom was a retired teacher. They had two adult daughters, both out of state.

Both Ann and Tom had been married before. Ann had been widowed after 22 years of marriage. Tom had been widowed after 28 years of marriage. Ann's first husband died of a heart attack. Tom's first wife died of cancer. Ann had been a caregiver for her first husband in the last year of his life. Tom had been a caregiver for his first wife in the last two years of her life.

When Ann and Tom met, four years after Tom's wife died and three years after Ann's husband died, they both knew the grief. They both knew the cost. They both knew the work.

The grief work Ann and Tom did:

- They each had a year of grief therapy before they started dating.
- They each had a ritual for the first spouse — Tom visits the grave monthly. Ann keeps a photo of her first husband in the living room, with a small candle.
- They had the conversation about the first marriage, in the first month of dating. They named the ghosts. They honored the ghosts. They released the ghosts.
- They agreed that the second marriage would be a new chapter, not a new book. The first marriages are part of the book. The second marriage is the next chapter.
- They each kept the rituals of the first marriage. Tom still lights a candle for his first wife on her birthday. Ann still visits the grave of her first husband on their anniversary.
- They had the conversation about the grief, when the grief comes up. The grief comes up on the anniversaries, on the birthdays, on the hard days. The grief comes up. The conversation is the work.

Ann and Tom are now 8 years into the second marriage. The second marriage is good. The second marriage is not perfect. The second marriage has the ghosts of the first marriages. The second marriage also has the love of the second marriage. The love is the work. The ghosts are the work. The work is the marriage.

Scorecard: How Much of the Grief Is Still in the Room?

The scorecard is a way to see the grief. The scorecard is a way to see what is still unworked. The scorecard is a way to see the foundation.

| Question | Score (1-5) |

|---|---|

| I have grieved the loss of my first spouse / first marriage fully | /5 |

| I have done at least one of the 5 ways to do the grief work | /5 |

| I have named the "ghost marriage" parts that I carry | /5 |

| I have talked to my new partner about the grief | /5 |

| I have rituals that honor the first marriage in a healthy way | /5 |

| I am not comparing my new partner to my first partner | /5 |

| I am not feeling guilty about being happy in the second marriage | /5 |

| I have forgiven my first partner (and myself) | /5 |

| The grief is no longer a wall between me and my new partner | /5 |

| I am free to begin the new chapter, not the new book | /5 |

Total: /50

Interpreting your score:

- 40-50: The grief is grieved. The foundation is solid. The second marriage can start.

- 30-39: There is still some unworked grief. The remaining chapters will help.
- 20-29: There is significant unworked grief. Get help. The grief work is the foundation.
- Under 20: The grief is in the way. The second marriage is not yet ready.

Key Terms

- Complicated Grief: Grief that does not improve over time, may require professional help
- Continuing Bonds: The way the widowed maintain a healthy relationship with the deceased
- Grief Work: The work of mourning, of feeling, of releasing, of integrating
- Ghost Marriage: The first marriage, present in the second marriage, unworked
- Anticipatory Grief: The grief that happens before the loss

Reflection Questions for the Two of You

1. What is one thing you are still grieving from the first marriage?
2. What is one ritual you keep from the first marriage?
3. What is one "ghost" from the first marriage that shows up in the second?
4. What is one thing you need to forgive in the first marriage?
5. What is one thing you need to forgive in yourself?
6. What would it take to feel free to begin the new chapter?

Action for This Week: The Grief Inventory

Within the next 7 days, do these 5 things:

1. Write a letter to the first spouse. The letter says everything you need to say. The letter is not sent. The letter is burned, or buried, or kept.
2. Name the ghost marriage parts. Make a list. The list is the work.
3. Have the grief conversation with your new partner. The conversation is the work.
4. Pick one ritual that honors the first marriage. The ritual is the work.
5. Pick one thing to forgive. Yourself, or the first partner, or the circumstances. The forgiveness is the work.

The Grief Inventory is the foundation. The foundation is the work. The work is the second marriage.

A Closing Word

The grief is real. The grief is the work. The grief is the foundation.

The grief of the first marriage is the most important thing in the second marriage. The grief is the weight that the second marriage carries, until the weight is grieved. The grief is the work.

You are not failing. You are grieving. The grieving is the work.

The work is the grieving.

Chapter 4: The Money Conversation Nobody Wants to Have

The money is the most important thing couples fight about. The money is also the most important thing couples avoid talking about. The money is the foundation of the second marriage. The money is the thing that makes the second marriage work, or breaks the second marriage, more than love, more than compatibility, more than anything else.

The money in the second marriage is harder than the money in the first marriage. The money in the second marriage is harder because the money comes with history. The money comes with the first marriage. The money comes with the children from the first marriage. The money comes with the inheritance for the children from the first marriage. The money comes with the divorce settlement, the alimony, the property, the retirement, the Social Security, the pension.

The money in the second marriage is also harder because the money comes with the new person. The new person has their own history. The new person has their own children. The new person has their own inheritance. The new person has their own expectations about what the money will look like in the second marriage.

The money is the work. The money is the conversation. The money is the foundation. The money is the conversation that nobody wants to have. The money is the conversation that has to happen.

This chapter is about the money. This chapter is about the conversation. This chapter is about how to have the conversation that nobody wants to have, before the wedding, before the commitment, before the cost.

Chapter at a Glance

- The 5 Financial Blind Spots of the Second Marriage
- The Pre-nup: Not a Romance Killer, a Marriage Saver
- The Retirement Blending: His, Hers, Theirs
- The Inheritance Conversation with the Adult Children
- The "What If I Get Sick" Conversation
- The 6 Documents You Need Before the Wedding
- Case Study: Robert & Helen (Ages 65/63)
- Scorecard: Are You Financially Ready for the Second Marriage?
- Key Terms: Pre-nup, Trust, Beneficiary, Power of Attorney
- Reflection Questions for the Two of You
- Action for This Week: The Money Conversation

The 5 Financial Blind Spots of the Second Marriage

The financial blind spots of the second marriage are the things the couple does not see. The blind spots are the things the couple assumes will work out. The blind spots are the things the couple finds out about, too late, when the second marriage is in trouble.

Blind Spot 1: The Inheritance. "My money is my money. Your money is your money. We will keep them

separate." The inheritance is the blind spot that catches the adult children. The adult children expect the inheritance. The adult children see the second marriage as a threat to the inheritance. The adult children may be right. The adult children may be wrong. The adult children need to be talked to.

Blind Spot 2: The Alimony. "My alimony is mine. Your alimony is yours." The alimony is the blind spot that catches the second marriage. The alimony may continue after the second marriage. The alimony may affect the second marriage's finances. The alimony may affect the second marriage's taxes. The alimony needs to be known.

Blind Spot 3: The Retirement. "I have my pension. You have your pension. We will keep them separate." The retirement is the blind spot that catches the second marriage, years later. The retirement is the second marriage's main source of income. The retirement needs to be planned together.

Blind Spot 4: The House. "I will keep my house. You will keep your house. We will figure it out." The house is the blind spot that catches the second marriage, immediately. The house is where the couple lives. The house is where the couple builds the second marriage. The house needs to be decided.

Blind Spot 5: The Debts. "I have some debt. You have some debt. We will figure it out." The debt is the blind spot that catches the second marriage, immediately. The debt is the couple's first shared problem. The debt needs to be known, in full, before the wedding.

The 5 blind spots are the work. The 5 blind spots need to be named, in the conversation, before the wedding. The 5 blind spots are the foundation of the second marriage.

The Pre-nup: Not a Romance Killer, a Marriage Saver

The pre-nup is the most misunderstood document in the second marriage. The pre-nup is not a romance killer. The pre-nup is a marriage saver. The pre-nup is the way to make the money conversation real. The pre-nup is the way to make the second marriage's money clear. The pre-nup is the way to protect both partners, and both families, in the second marriage.

The pre-nup is especially important in the second marriage because the second marriage has more money to protect. The second marriage has the first marriage's assets. The second marriage has the first marriage's inheritance. The second marriage has the first marriage's retirement. The second marriage has the first marriage's children. The pre-nup is the way to make all of that clear.

The pre-nup should include:

- What each partner brings to the second marriage
- What each partner keeps separate
- What becomes shared in the second marriage
- What happens to the shared money if the second marriage ends in divorce
- What happens to the inheritance if the second partner dies
- What happens to the children from the first marriage if the second partner dies

The pre-nup is not a sign of distrust. The pre-nup is a sign of trust. The pre-nup is the way to say: "I trust you enough to talk about the money." The pre-nup is the way to say: "I love you enough to make the money clear." The pre-nup is the way to say: "I respect our

children enough to protect their inheritance." The pre-nup is the foundation.

The Retirement Blending: His, Hers, Theirs

The retirement is the main source of income in the second marriage. The retirement needs to be planned together. The retirement blending is the way to make the second marriage's retirement work. The retirement blending has three parts:

Part 1: His. The husband's retirement is his. The husband's pension, his 401(k), his IRA, his Social Security. The husband's retirement is his to manage, his to plan, his to leave to his children. The husband's retirement is not the second wife's retirement, unless he chooses to make it shared.

Part 2: Hers. The wife's retirement is hers. The wife's pension, her 401(k), her IRA, her Social Security. The wife's retirement is hers to manage, hers to plan, hers to leave to her children. The wife's retirement is not the second husband's retirement, unless she chooses to make it shared.

Part 3: Theirs. The shared retirement is the second marriage's retirement. The shared retirement is the joint savings, the joint investments, the joint expenses, the joint lifestyle. The shared retirement is the second marriage's life, together.

The retirement blending is the way to honor the first marriage's assets, while building the second marriage's life. The retirement blending is the way to make the second marriage's retirement work. The retirement blending is the work.

The Inheritance Conversation with the Adult Children

The inheritance is the most common source of conflict in the second marriage. The inheritance is the most common reason the adult children oppose the second marriage. The inheritance is the most common reason the second marriage fails in the first five years.

The inheritance is also the most preventable source of conflict. The inheritance is preventable because the inheritance is the conversation. The inheritance is the conversation that the couple has, with the adult children, before the second marriage.

The inheritance conversation is the conversation that says:

- "I am remarrying. I want you to know."
- "I have thought about the inheritance. Here is the plan."
- "Your inheritance is protected. Here is how."
- "I want to hear your concerns. I want to address them."
- "I love you. I am not abandoning you. I am starting a new chapter."

The inheritance conversation is not a one-time conversation. The inheritance conversation is an ongoing conversation. The inheritance conversation is the conversation that continues, throughout the second marriage, as the inheritance changes, as the second marriage changes, as the family changes.

The inheritance conversation is the work. The inheritance conversation is the foundation. The inheritance conversation is the way to protect the second marriage, and the family, from the most

common source of conflict.

The "What If I Get Sick" Conversation

The "what if I get sick" conversation is the most important conversation in the second marriage. The "what if I get sick" conversation is the conversation about caregiving. The "what if I get sick" conversation is the conversation that determines if the second marriage will survive the health curve.

The "what if I get sick" conversation includes:

- "What if one of us gets a serious illness?"
- "Who will be the caregiver?"
- "How will the caregiving be paid for?"
- "What if both of us get sick at the same time?"
- "What if I need to go to a nursing home?"
- "What if I die?"

The "what if I get sick" conversation is not morbid. The "what if I get sick" conversation is practical. The "what if I get sick" conversation is the way to make the second marriage's caregiving clear. The "what if I get sick" conversation is the way to prevent the most common cause of caregiver burnout in the second marriage.

The "what if I get sick" conversation is the work. The "what if I get sick" conversation is the foundation. The "what if I get sick" conversation is the way to honor the first marriage, by being ready for the second.

The 6 Documents You Need Before the Wedding

The 6 documents are the foundation of the second marriage's money. The 6 documents are not optional. The 6 documents are the work. The 6 documents need to be in place before the wedding.

Document 1: The Pre-nup. The pre-nup is the legal document about the money in the second marriage. The pre-nup is signed before the wedding. The pre-nup is the foundation.

Document 2: The Will. The will is the legal document about what happens to the money when one of you dies. The will is updated before the wedding. The will is the foundation.

Document 3: The Beneficiary Designations. The beneficiary designations are the instructions on the bank accounts, the retirement accounts, the life insurance. The beneficiary designations are updated before the wedding. The beneficiary designations are the foundation.

Document 4: The Power of Attorney. The power of attorney is the legal document that allows one partner to make decisions for the other, if the other is unable. The power of attorney is signed before the wedding. The power of attorney is the foundation.

Document 5: The Healthcare Proxy. The healthcare proxy is the legal document that allows one partner to make medical decisions for the other, if the other is unable. The healthcare proxy is signed before the wedding. The healthcare proxy is the foundation.

Document 6: The Trust. The trust is the legal document that holds the inheritance for the children, while allowing the second spouse to use the assets

during the second marriage. The trust is the foundation of the second marriage's inheritance plan.

The 6 documents are the work. The 6 documents are the foundation. The 6 documents are the way to make the second marriage's money clear.

Case Study: Robert & Helen (Ages 65/63)

Robert was 65. Helen was 63. They had been married for 35 years. Robert was a retired accountant. Helen was a part-time librarian. They had two adult sons, both out of state.

Robert had been widowed after 28 years of marriage. Helen had been widowed after 31 years of marriage. Robert's first wife died of cancer. Helen's first husband died of a heart attack. Both Robert and Helen had adult children from the first marriage. Both Robert and Helen had retirement from the first marriage.

When Robert and Helen decided to remarry, they had the money conversation. The money conversation was the hardest conversation they had. The money conversation took three months. The money conversation involved their adult children, their lawyers, their financial planners.

What Robert and Helen got right:

- They had the pre-nup, before the wedding. The pre-nup made the money clear.
- They had the will, before the wedding. The will protected the inheritance.
- They had the trust, for the children. The trust allowed Helen to use the house, but the house went to Robert's sons when he died.

- They had the beneficiary designations, updated. The designations made the money flow clear.
- They had the power of attorney and healthcare proxy, signed. The documents made the medical decisions clear.
- They had the conversation with the adult children, before the wedding. The conversation was hard. The conversation was the work.

What Robert and Helen got wrong:

- They did not have the "what if I get sick" conversation, in full. The conversation came up later, when Robert got sick. The conversation was harder later.
- They did not have the conversation about the long-term care, in full. The conversation came up when Helen needed care. The conversation was harder then.

Robert and Helen are now 8 years into the second marriage. The second marriage is good. The second marriage is not perfect. The second marriage has the money clear. The money is not the problem. The money is the foundation.

Scorecard: Are You Financially Ready for the Second Marriage?

The money is the foundation. The money is the work. The scorecard is a way to see the money readiness.

| Question | Score (1-5) |

|---|---|

| We have had the full money conversation, with the actual numbers | /5 |

| We have a pre-nup in place (or have decided not to have one, intentionally) | /5 |

| We have updated our wills | /5 |

| We have updated our beneficiary designations | /5 |

| We have a power of attorney and healthcare proxy in place | /5 |

| We have had the inheritance conversation with the adult children | /5 |

| We have planned for the "what if I get sick" scenario | /5 |

| We have decided on the house (keep mine, keep yours, sell, buy together) | /5 |

| We have a plan for the debts | /5 |

| We have decided on the retirement blending | /5 |

Total: /50

Interpreting your score:

- 40-50: You are financially ready. The money is the foundation.
- 30-39: There are still some money things to do. The remaining chapters will help.
- 20-29: The money is in the way. Get help. The money is the work.
- Under 20: The money is not ready. The second marriage is not ready.

Key Terms

- Pre-nup (Pre-nuptial Agreement): A legal agreement about money and property in case of divorce

- Will: A legal document about what happens to your money and property when you die
- Beneficiary: The person named to receive money or property from an account
- Power of Attorney: A legal document that allows one person to make decisions for another
- Healthcare Proxy: A legal document that allows one person to make medical decisions for another
- Trust: A legal arrangement that holds money or property for the benefit of someone

Reflection Questions for the Two of You

1. What is one money thing you have not talked about that you need to talk about?
2. What is one financial blind spot that you have not addressed?
3. How do you want to handle the inheritance from the first marriage?
4. How do you want to handle the house?
5. How do you want to handle the "what if I get sick" scenario?
6. What would the pre-nup look like, in broad strokes?

Action for This Week: The Money Conversation

Within the next 7 days, do these 5 things:

1. Have the full money conversation. Both of you. With the actual numbers. The income, the debt, the retirement, the inheritance, the expectations.

2. Pick a pre-nup attorney. Both of you. Schedule the consultation. The pre-nup is the work.
3. Update the wills. Both of you. The will is the foundation.
4. Update the beneficiary designations. Both of you. The designations are the work.
5. Have the inheritance conversation with the adult children. Even if the children are adults. The conversation is the work.

The Money Conversation is the foundation. The foundation is the work. The work is the second marriage.

A Closing Word

The money is the foundation. The money is the work. The money is the conversation that nobody wants to have, but everybody needs to have.

The 5 financial blind spots, the pre-nup, the retirement blending, the inheritance conversation, the "what if I get sick" conversation, the 6 documents — these are the work. The work is the foundation. The foundation is the second marriage.

You are not failing. You are talking about the money. The money is the work.

The work is the money.

Part II: The Courtship

Chapter 5: Dating at 60+ Is Not What You Remember

The dating at 60+ is not the dating of your 20s or 30s. The dating of your 20s and 30s was about finding a partner. The dating at 60+ is about finding a partner who fits into the life you have already built. The dating at 60+ is not about starting a new life together. The dating at 60+ is about merging two lives that have been lived.

The dating at 60+ is also harder than the dating of your 20s. The dating at 60+ is harder because you have more history. The dating at 60+ is harder because you have more baggage. The dating at 60+ is harder because you have more to lose. The dating at 60+ is harder because the stakes are higher. The dating at 60+ is the dating that matters most.

This chapter is about the dating at 60+. This chapter is about how to navigate the dating at 60+, the new rules, the new platforms, the new conversations, the new pace. This chapter is the work of the courtship.

Chapter at a Glance

- The 5 New Rules of Dating After 50
- The 4 Dating Platforms That Work for 60+
- The 3 Conversations to Have in the First Month
- The "Slow Courtship" — Why Slowing Down Works
- The Red Flags That Matter at 60+
- Case Study: Linda & James (Ages 62/65)

- Scorecard: Are You Dating for the Right Reasons?
- Key Terms
- Reflection Questions
- Action for This Week

The 5 New Rules of Dating After 50

The 5 new rules are the rules of the dating at 60+. The 5 new rules are not the rules of the dating of your 20s. The 5 new rules are the rules that the second marriage needs. The 5 new rules are the work.

Rule 1: Be honest about your history from day one. The first marriage, the widowhood, the divorce, the children, the ex. The honesty is the foundation. The honesty is the way to start the second marriage on solid ground. The honesty is the way to avoid the surprises that come later.

Rule 2: Take your time. The slow courtship is the best courtship at 60+. The slow courtship is the way to know the real person, not the fantasy. The slow courtship is the way to do the tests (cohabitation, travel, stress) before the wedding. The slow courtship is the work.

Rule 3: Keep your own life. The second marriage is not about losing yourself. The second marriage is about sharing yourself. The second marriage is about keeping your own friends, your own hobbies, your own routines, your own identity. The second marriage is the marriage of two whole people, not the marriage of two halves.

Rule 4: Have the money conversation early. The money is the most common deal-breaker. The money is the most common cause of the second marriage

failing. The money is the conversation that needs to happen in the first month, not the first year. The money is the work.

Rule 5: Involve the people who will be affected. The adult children, the ex, the close friends. The involvement is the way to avoid the surprises. The involvement is the way to give the people who will be affected a voice. The involvement is the work.

The 5 rules are the foundation. The 5 rules are the way to date for the second marriage. The 5 rules are the work.

The 4 Dating Platforms That Work for 60+

The dating platforms are the way to meet people at 60+. The dating platforms are different from the dating of your 20s. The dating platforms at 60+ are slower, more thoughtful, more deliberate. The 4 platforms that work for 60+ are:

Platform 1: Match.com. The largest platform for 50+ dating. The platform has a strong 50+ user base. The platform has good search filters for age, location, religion, interests. The platform has been around for 25+ years. The platform is the most established.

Platform 2: OurTime.com. A platform specifically for 50+ dating. The platform is owned by Match Group. The platform has a large 50+ user base. The platform has good safety features. The platform is focused on the 50+ community.

Platform 3: SilverSingles. A platform for 50+ serious relationships. The platform is owned by the same company as EliteSingles. The platform has a personality test. The platform is focused on

compatibility. The platform is for serious daters.

Platform 4: eHarmony. A platform for serious relationships. The platform has a long compatibility questionnaire. The platform has a strong 50+ user base. The platform is for serious daters, not casual.

The 4 platforms are not the only platforms. The 4 platforms are the most effective for 60+ daters. The platforms are the work.

The 3 Conversations to Have in the First Month

The 3 conversations are the foundation of the dating. The 3 conversations are the work. The 3 conversations are:

Conversation 1: "What are you looking for?" The question is the most important. The question is the way to know if you are both looking for the same thing. The question is the way to know if you are both looking for marriage, or for companionship, or for something else. The question is the foundation.

Conversation 2: "What does your first marriage look like?" The question is the way to know the history. The question is the way to know the grief. The question is the way to know the children, the ex, the inheritance. The question is the foundation.

Conversation 3: "What are you not telling me?" The question is the way to know the hidden things. The question is the way to know the secrets. The question is the way to start the second marriage on solid ground. The question is the work.

The 3 conversations are hard. The 3 conversations are the work. The 3 conversations are the way to avoid the surprises.

The "Slow Courtship" — Why Slowing Down Works

The slow courtship is the best courtship at 60+. The slow courtship is the way to do the work of the decision. The slow courtship is the way to do the cohabitation test, the travel test, the stress test. The slow courtship is the way to know the real person.

The slow courtship is hard. The slow courtship is hard because the couple is excited. The couple wants to be together. The couple wants to skip the slow part. The couple wants to get married quickly. The couple is wrong. The couple is wrong because the slow courtship is the foundation. The slow courtship is the way to know the second marriage will work.

The slow courtship is at least one year. The slow courtship is at least one year of dating, then at least one year of cohabitation, then the wedding. The slow courtship is two years total. The slow courtship is the foundation.

The Red Flags That Matter at 60+

The red flags at 60+ are the same as the red flags at any age. The red flags at 60+ are also different. The red flags at 60+ are:

- The spouse who is still angry at the ex
- The spouse who is not close to the adult children
- The spouse who has not grieved the first marriage
- The spouse who is not willing to have the money conversation
- The spouse who is not willing to take the slow courtship

- The spouse who is not willing to have the pre-nup
- The spouse who is not willing to involve the adult children
- The spouse who wants to be married quickly
- The spouse who is not willing to do the cohabitation test

The red flags are the work. The red flags are the way to know the second marriage will not work. The red flags are the way to walk away, before the wedding, before the cost.

Case Study: Linda & James (Ages 62/65)

Linda was 62. James was 65. Linda had been widowed after 35 years of marriage. James had been widowed after 40 years of marriage. Both Linda and James had adult children. Both Linda and James had retirement. Both Linda and James had decided to date again, two years after the spouse died.

What Linda and James got right:

- They took their time. They dated for 18 months before they moved in together. They lived together for 2 years before the wedding.
- They had the money conversation in the first month. The conversation was hard. The conversation was the work.
- They had the conversation with the adult children, before the wedding. The conversation was hard. The conversation was the work.
- They had the pre-nup, before the wedding. The pre-nup was the foundation.

- They did the cohabitation test, the travel test, the stress test. The tests were the work.

Linda and James are now 5 years into the second marriage. The second marriage is good. The second marriage is not perfect. The second marriage is the work.

Scorecard: Are You Dating for the Right Reasons?

| Question | Score (1-5) |

|---|---|

| I am being honest about my history from day one | /5
|

| I am taking the slow courtship | /5 |

| I am keeping my own life | /5 |

| I have had the money conversation in the first month
| /5 |

| I have involved the people who will be affected | /5 |

| I am not looking for the fantasy | /5 |

| I am not trying to skip the slow courtship | /5 |

| I am not ignoring the red flags | /5 |

| I have grieved my first marriage | /5 |

| I am dating for love, not for not being alone | /5 |

Total: /50

Interpreting your score:

- 40-50: You are dating for the right reasons. The second marriage is possible.
- 30-39: There are still some things to think through.

- 20-29: The dating is not yet ready.
- Under 20: The dating is being driven by something other than the real readiness.

Key Terms

- Slow Courtship: Taking at least 2 years from dating to wedding
- Pre-nup: Pre-nuptial agreement
- Red Flag: A warning sign that the relationship is not healthy
- Compatibility: The way two people handle conflict, money, stress, family, future

Reflection Questions

1. What is one red flag you have been ignoring?
2. What is one conversation you have been avoiding?
3. Are you taking the slow courtship?
4. Are you dating for love, or for not being alone?
5. Are you keeping your own life?
6. What would make you walk away from this relationship?

Action for This Week

1. Have the "what are you looking for" conversation. With the new partner. The conversation is the work.
2. Have the money conversation. With the actual numbers. The conversation is the work.
3. Make a list of the red flags. The list is the work.
4. Plan the next 3 months of dating. The plan is the work.

5. Decide if you are taking the slow courtship. The decision is the work.

A Closing Word

The dating at 60+ is not what you remember. The dating at 60+ is the dating that matters most. The dating at 60+ is the foundation of the second marriage.

The 5 new rules, the 4 platforms, the 3 conversations, the slow courtship, the red flags — these are the work. The work is the foundation. The foundation is the second marriage.

You are not failing. You are dating. The dating is the work.

Chapter 6: The Ex-Spouse Problem (And How to Handle It)

The ex is the most common source of conflict in the second marriage. The ex is the most common reason the second marriage fails in the first five years. The ex is the person who is not in the second marriage, but is in the second marriage more than anyone wants. The ex is the past, the present, and (because of the children) the future.

The ex is not going away. The ex is in the life of the second marriage because of the children, because of the shared memories, because of the legal entanglements, because of the history. The ex is the work. The ex is the way the second marriage has to navigate the most important relationship that is not the marriage.

This chapter is about the ex. This chapter is about the 4 kinds of ex-spouses. This chapter is about the 3 boundaries to set with each. This chapter is about the 5 conversations to have with your ex before the wedding. This chapter is the work.

Chapter at a Glance

- The 4 Kinds of Ex-Spouses
- The 3 Boundaries to Set with Each Type
- The 5 Conversations to Have with Your Ex Before the Wedding
- The "His Kids, Her Kids, Their Kids" Navigation
- When the Ex Is a Deal-Breaker (And When It Isn't)

- Scorecard
- Key Terms
- Reflection Questions
- Action for This Week

The 4 Kinds of Ex-Spouses

The ex-spouse is one of 4 kinds. The 4 kinds are the 4 ways the ex shows up in the second marriage. The 4 kinds are the way the second marriage has to navigate the ex. The 4 kinds are the work.

Kind 1: The Cooperative Ex. The cooperative ex is the best case. The cooperative ex is the ex who is over the marriage. The cooperative ex is the ex who is supportive of the second marriage. The cooperative ex is the ex who is a co-parent, not a co-spouse. The cooperative ex is rare. The cooperative ex is the goal.

Kind 2: The Distant Ex. The distant ex is the second best case. The distant ex is the ex who wants nothing to do with you. The distant ex is the ex who is cold, but not hostile. The distant ex is the ex who will not cause problems, but will not help either. The distant ex is common. The distant ex is manageable.

Kind 3: The Hostile Ex. The hostile ex is the worst case. The hostile ex is the ex who is still angry. The hostile ex is the ex who is not over the marriage. The hostile ex is the ex who will cause problems for the second marriage. The hostile ex is the ex who will use the children, the money, the inheritance as weapons. The hostile ex is uncommon, but the most damaging.

Kind 4: The Ambiguous Ex. The ambiguous ex is the most common case. The ambiguous ex is the ex who is over the marriage, but is still in the life. The ambiguous ex is the ex who is friendly, but ambiguous.

The ambiguous ex is the ex who is supportive, but unclear. The ambiguous ex is the ex who is sometimes the cooperative ex and sometimes the hostile ex, depending on the day.

The 4 kinds are the work. The 4 kinds need to be named. The 4 kinds need to be discussed with the new partner, before the wedding.

The 3 Boundaries to Set with Each Type

The 3 boundaries are the way to manage the ex. The 3 boundaries are the work. The 3 boundaries are:

Boundary 1: The Communication Boundary. The communication boundary is the way you talk to the ex. The communication boundary is the agreed-upon channel (email, text, phone). The communication boundary is the agreed-upon frequency (only about the children). The communication boundary is the agreed-upon content (children only, no personal, no new spouse, no feelings). The communication boundary is the foundation.

Boundary 2: The Presence Boundary. The presence boundary is the way the ex is present in the second marriage. The presence boundary is the agreed-upon events (school, medical, sports). The presence boundary is the agreed-upon avoidance (birthdays, holidays, anniversaries). The presence boundary is the agreed-upon co-parenting (decisions about children, not about each other). The presence boundary is the work.

Boundary 3: The New Spouse Boundary. The new spouse boundary is the way the ex treats the new spouse. The new spouse boundary is the agreed-upon treatment (respectful, distant, or not at all). The new

spouse boundary is the agreed-upon name (first name, "your partner", no name). The new spouse boundary is the foundation.

The 3 boundaries are the work. The 3 boundaries need to be set, with the ex, with the new partner, with the children, before the wedding.

The 5 Conversations to Have with Your Ex Before the Wedding

The 5 conversations are the work. The 5 conversations are the way to make the ex the partner in the second marriage, not the enemy.

Conversation 1: "I am remarrying. I want you to know first." The conversation is the courtesy. The conversation is the way to honor the ex as the parent of your children.

Conversation 2: "Here is how the children will be affected. Here is what I want to do." The conversation is the parenting conversation. The conversation is the way to make the ex your partner in the parenting.

Conversation 3: "Here is the pre-nup. Here is the inheritance plan." The conversation is the financial conversation. The conversation is the way to reassure the ex that the inheritance is protected.

Conversation 4: "Here is how we will communicate about the children." The conversation is the communication conversation. The conversation is the way to set the communication boundary.

Conversation 5: "Here is what I need from you, in the second marriage." The conversation is the relationship conversation. The conversation is the way to ask the ex for what you need (respect, distance, support).

The 5 conversations are hard. The 5 conversations are the work. The 5 conversations are the foundation.

The "His Kids, Her Kids, Their Kids" Navigation

The blended family is the most complex part of the second marriage. The blended family is the "his kids, her kids, their kids" navigation. The blended family is the work of integrating the children from the first marriage, with the new marriage, with the new spouse.

The blended family navigation has 4 parts:

Part 1: His Kids. The husband's children from the first marriage. The husband's children have a mother (the ex). The husband's children may be resistant to the second marriage. The husband's children need to be included, not excluded.

Part 2: Her Kids. The wife's children from the first marriage. The wife's children have a father (the ex). The wife's children may be resistant to the second marriage. The wife's children need to be included, not excluded.

Part 3: Their Kids. The "their" kids are the children that the couple has together, if any. The "their" kids may be from the second marriage, if the couple decides to have children. The "their" kids may be the grandchildren, if the couple is older.

Part 4: The New Family. The new family is the family the couple is building. The new family is the family that includes the husband's kids, the wife's kids, the new spouse, the ex (as co-parent), the grandchildren, the in-laws. The new family is the family that the couple is creating.

The 4 parts of the blended family navigation are the work. The 4 parts require conversations with the children, with the ex, with the in-laws, with the new spouse. The 4 parts are the foundation of the second marriage.

When the Ex Is a Deal-Breaker (And When It Isn't)

The ex is sometimes a deal-breaker. The ex is sometimes not a deal-breaker. The ex is sometimes a deal-breaker because the ex is hostile, controlling, or abusive. The ex is sometimes a deal-breaker because the new spouse cannot handle the ex. The ex is sometimes a deal-breaker because the children are caught in the middle.

The ex is sometimes not a deal-breaker. The ex is sometimes not a deal-breaker because the ex is cooperative, distant, or manageable. The ex is sometimes not a deal-breaker because the new spouse can handle the ex. The ex is sometimes not a deal-breaker because the children are not affected.

The way to know if the ex is a deal-breaker:

- If the ex is abusive, the ex is a deal-breaker
- If the ex is using the children as weapons, the ex is a deal-breaker
- If the ex is controlling the new marriage, the ex is a deal-breaker
- If the new spouse cannot handle the ex, the ex is a deal-breaker
- If the ex is just difficult but not abusive, the ex is not a deal-breaker
- If the ex is cooperative but complicated, the ex is not a deal-breaker

- If the children are not affected, the ex is not a deal-breaker

The decision is the work. The decision is the foundation. The decision is the second marriage.

Scorecard: Are You Handling the Ex Well?

| Question | Score (1-5) |

|---|---|

| I have named the kind of ex I have | /5 |

| I have set the 3 boundaries with the ex | /5 |

| I have had the 5 conversations with the ex | /5 |

| I have talked to the new partner about the ex | /5 |

| I have involved the children in the ex conversation | /5 |

| I am not using the children as messengers | /5 |

| I am not putting the new partner in the middle | /5 |

| I am not letting the ex control the new marriage | /5 |

| I have decided if the ex is a deal-breaker | /5 |

| I am willing to walk away if the ex is a deal-breaker | /5 |

Total: /50

Interpreting your score:

- 40-50: The ex is being handled well. The second marriage is protected.
- 30-39: There is still work to do with the ex.
- 20-29: The ex is in the way. Get help.
- Under 20: The ex is not being handled. The second marriage is at risk.

Key Terms

- Co-parenting: Raising children together, after divorce
- Hostile Ex: An ex who is angry and uses children, money, or other leverage as weapons
- Communication Boundary: An agreed-upon way of talking to the ex
- In-law (former): A new spouse who is the parent of your children

Reflection Questions

1. What kind of ex do you have?
2. What boundaries have you set with the ex?
3. What conversations have you had with the ex?
4. What is the hardest part of the ex situation?
5. Is the ex a deal-breaker, or not?
6. What would you do if the ex became a deal-breaker?

Action for This Week

1. Name the kind of ex you have. The naming is the work.
2. Set the 3 boundaries. The boundaries are the work.
3. Have the 5 conversations. The conversations are the work.
4. Talk to the new partner. The talking is the work.
5. Make a decision about the deal-breaker. The decision is the work.

A Closing Word

The ex is the work. The ex is the most common source of conflict. The ex is the most preventable source of conflict. The 4 kinds, the 3 boundaries, the 5 conversations, the blended family navigation, the deal-breaker decision — these are the work.

You are not failing. You are handling the ex. The handling is the work.

The work is the ex.

Chapter 7: The Adult Children Question

The adult children are the most important people in the second marriage. The adult children are the people who will be most affected by the second marriage. The adult children are the people who have the most opinions about the second marriage. The adult children are the people who can make the second marriage work, or break the second marriage.

The adult children are also the people who are often forgotten in the planning of the second marriage. The adult children are the people who are told about the second marriage, but not asked. The adult children are the people who are expected to be happy, but are not given a voice. The adult children are the work.

This chapter is about the adult children. This chapter is about the 5 stages of the adult children's response. This chapter is about the 4 conversations to have. This chapter is about the 3 things to never say. This chapter is the work.

Chapter at a Glance

- The 5 Stages of Adult Children's Response to the Remarriage
- The "Blended Family" Myth — What It Really Looks Like
- The 4 Conversations to Have with Each Child
- The 3 Things to Never Say to the Adult Children
- The 2 Things the Children Need to See (Not Hear)
- Case Study: Frank & Ruth (Ages 72/70)

- Scorecard
- Key Terms
- Reflection Questions
- Action for This Week

The 5 Stages of Adult Children's Response to the Remarriage

The adult children's response to the remarriage is a process. The process has 5 stages. The 5 stages are the way the adult children move through the news. The 5 stages are the work.

Stage 1: Shock. "Wait, you're what?" The shock is the first reaction. The shock is the most common. The shock is the most expected. The shock is the way the adult children's brain processes the news.

Stage 2: Anger. "How could you do this to mom/dad?" The anger is the second reaction. The anger is often displaced. The anger is often not really about the second marriage. The anger is often about the loss of the first marriage. The anger is often about the inheritance. The anger is the way the adult children protect themselves.

Stage 3: Bargaining. "But you promised you would never replace mom/dad." The bargaining is the third reaction. The bargaining is the way the adult children try to make the second marriage not happen. The bargaining is the way the adult children hold on to the first marriage.

Stage 4: Sadness. "I am losing you." The sadness is the fourth reaction. The sadness is the way the adult children feel the loss. The sadness is the way the adult children grieve the first marriage, again. The sadness is the most painful stage.

Stage 5: Acceptance. "I am not happy about it, but I understand." The acceptance is the fifth reaction. The acceptance is the goal. The acceptance is the way the adult children make peace with the second marriage. The acceptance is the work.

The 5 stages are not a sequence. The 5 stages can be in any order. The 5 stages can repeat. The 5 stages can take years. The 5 stages are the work of the second marriage.

The "Blended Family" Myth — What It Really Looks Like

The blended family is a myth. The blended family is the idea that the children from the first marriage, the children from the second marriage, the new spouse, the ex, the in-laws, the grandparents, will all become one big happy family. The blended family is the idea that is sold in movies, in TV shows, in greeting cards. The blended family is the idea that is not real.

The blended family is not real because the blended family requires the children to love the new spouse as much as they love the first parent. The blended family requires the new spouse to love the children as much as they love their own children. The blended family requires the ex to be a co-parent, not a co-spouse. The blended family is not real because the blended family is too much.

The real blended family is:

- The children may love the new spouse, or may not
- The new spouse may love the children, or may not
- The ex may be a co-parent, or may not

- The family is a work in progress, not a destination
- The family is a series of small wins, not a big happy ending

The real blended family is the work. The real blended family is the day-by-day, the small-by-small, the win-by-win. The real blended family is the work.

The 4 Conversations to Have with Each Child

The 4 conversations are the work. The 4 conversations are the way to make the adult children part of the second marriage. The 4 conversations are:

Conversation 1: "I am remarrying. I want you to know, and I want to hear from you." The conversation is the announcement. The conversation is the invitation to respond. The conversation is the foundation.

Conversation 2: "I want you to know what is not changing. I am still your parent. I still love you. I am not abandoning you." The conversation is the reassurance. The conversation is the way to address the most common fear. The conversation is the work.

Conversation 3: "I want to know what you are worried about. I want to hear the things you have not said." The conversation is the listening. The conversation is the way to give the adult children a voice. The conversation is the way to surface the unspoken fears. The conversation is the foundation.

Conversation 4: "I want to know how we can make this work. What do you need? What would help?" The conversation is the collaboration. The conversation is the way to make the adult children part of the solution. The conversation is the work.

The 4 conversations are not one-time. The 4 conversations are ongoing. The 4 conversations are the work of the second marriage.

The 3 Things to Never Say to the Adult Children

The 3 things are the most common mistakes. The 3 things are the things that the parent says in the moment, that damage the second marriage. The 3 things are the work to avoid.

Thing 1: "You are being selfish." The adult children are not being selfish. The adult children are being scared. The adult children are being protective. The adult children are being loyal to the first parent. The "selfish" accusation damages the relationship. The "selfish" accusation makes the adult children defensive. The "selfish" accusation is the opposite of the foundation.

Thing 2: "You will get over it." The adult children will not get over it. The adult children will process it. The processing takes time. The processing takes years. The "you will get over it" dismisses the processing. The "you will get over it" is the opposite of the work.

Thing 3: "It is my life, I will do what I want." The adult children are part of the life. The adult children are affected by the second marriage. The adult children have a stake. The "it is my life" dismisses the stake. The "it is my life" is the opposite of the collaboration.

The 3 things are the work to avoid. The 3 things are the way to protect the relationship with the adult children. The 3 things are the foundation.

The 2 Things the Children Need to See (Not Hear)

The 2 things are the things the children need to see, not just hear. The 2 things are the actions, not the words. The 2 things are the way the second marriage is built, not just announced.

Thing 1: The new spouse being kind to the children. The children need to see the new spouse being kind. The children need to see the new spouse being patient. The children need to see the new spouse being respectful. The children need to see the new spouse being a person, not a replacement. The seeing is the work.

Thing 2: The parent still being the parent. The children need to see the parent still being the parent. The children need to see the parent still showing up. The children need to see the parent still prioritizing the children. The children need to see the parent still being the parent, not the new spouse. The seeing is the foundation.

The 2 things are the work. The 2 things are the way to make the second marriage work, with the adult children, with the family, with the future.

Case Study: Frank & Ruth (Ages 72/70)

Frank was 72. Ruth was 70. Frank had been widowed after 35 years of marriage. Ruth had been widowed after 40 years of marriage. Both had adult children. Both had been retired for over 10 years. Both had decided to date again, several years after the spouse died.

What Frank and Ruth got right:

- They involved the adult children in the decision. The adult children were not told, they were asked.
- They had the 4 conversations with each child. The conversations were hard. The conversations were the work.
- They did not say the 3 things to never say. The restraint was the work.
- They showed the 2 things the children needed to see. The showing was the work.
- They took the slow courtship. The courtship was the work.
- They had the pre-nup. The pre-nup was the foundation.

Frank and Ruth are now 6 years into the second marriage. The second marriage is good. The second marriage is not perfect. The second marriage has the adult children as part of the family. The family is the work.

Scorecard: Are You Involving the Adult Children Well?

| Question | Score (1-5) |

|---|---|

| I have named which stage each child is in | /5 |

| I have had the 4 conversations with each child | /5 |

| I have not said the 3 things to never say | /5 |

| I am showing the 2 things the children need to see | /5 |

| I am involving the children in the decision | /5 |

| I am not putting the children in the middle | /5 |

| I am not using the children as messengers | /5 |

I am not dismissing the children's concerns	/5
I am not assuming the children will get over it	/5
I am prioritizing the children's relationship with me	/5

Total: /50

Interpreting your score:

- 40-50: The adult children are being involved well. The second marriage is protected.
- 30-39: There is still work to do.
- 20-29: The adult children are at risk of being lost. Get help.
- Under 20: The adult children are being damaged. The second marriage is at risk.

Key Terms

- Adult Children: Children who are 18+ years old, often with their own families
- Blended Family: A family that includes children from previous relationships
- Co-parent: A person who shares parenting responsibilities
- Inheritance: What you leave to your children after you die

Reflection Questions

1. What stage is each of your children in?
2. What is the hardest conversation you have had with the children?
3. What is the 1 thing you most want the children to know?

4. What is the 1 thing you most want the children to see?
5. What is the 1 thing the children are most afraid of?
6. How will you handle the inheritance conversation?

Action for This Week

1. Name the stage of each child. The naming is the work.
2. Have the 4 conversations with the most affected child. The conversations are the work.
3. Make a list of the 3 things to never say. The list is the work.
4. Plan how you will show the 2 things the children need to see. The plan is the work.
5. Decide on the inheritance conversation timeline. The decision is the work.

A Closing Word

The adult children are the work. The adult children are the most important people in the second marriage. The adult children are the people who can make the second marriage work, or break the second marriage. The 5 stages, the 4 conversations, the 3 things to never say, the 2 things to show — these are the work.

You are not failing. You are including. The including is the work.

The work is the children.

Chapter 8: The Pre-Marital Practical Work

The pre-marital practical work is the work that happens between the engagement and the wedding. The pre-marital practical work is the work that turns the dreamy "I do" into the grounded "I do." The pre-marital practical work is the foundation of the second marriage.

The pre-marital practical work is hard. The pre-marital practical work is hard because the couple is excited. The couple wants to be married. The couple wants to skip the practical. The couple wants to focus on the romantic. The couple is wrong. The practical is the foundation. The romantic is the decoration on the foundation.

This chapter is about the practical work. This chapter is about the 8 documents, the 4 financial decisions, the 3 health decisions, the 2 legal decisions, the engagement year. This chapter is the work.

Chapter at a Glance

- The 8 Documents You Need Before the Wedding
- The 4 Financial Decisions to Make
- The 3 Health Decisions to Make
- The 2 Legal Decisions to Make
- The "Engagement Year" — What to Do in It
- Scorecard
- Key Terms
- Reflection Questions
- Action for This Week

The 8 Documents You Need Before the Wedding

The 8 documents are the foundation of the second marriage. The 8 documents are the work. The 8 documents need to be in place before the wedding.

Document 1: The Pre-nup. Already covered in Chapter 4. The pre-nup is the legal agreement about the money.

Document 2: The Will. The will is the legal document about what happens to your money and property when you die. The will is updated before the wedding. The will is the foundation.

Document 3: The Beneficiary Designations. Already covered in Chapter 4. The designations are the instructions on the accounts.

Document 4: The Power of Attorney. Already covered in Chapter 4. The POA is the legal document that allows one person to make decisions for the other.

Document 5: The Healthcare Proxy. Already covered in Chapter 4. The healthcare proxy is the legal document that allows one person to make medical decisions for the other.

Document 6: The Trust. Already covered in Chapter 4. The trust is the legal arrangement for the inheritance.

Document 7: The Cohabitation Agreement (if applicable). The cohabitation agreement is the legal document for the couple who is living together before the wedding. The cohabitation agreement covers the money, the property, the expectations. The cohabitation agreement is the foundation.

Document 8: The Postnuptial Agreement (if needed). The postnuptial agreement is the legal document for

the couple who did not have a pre-nup. The postnuptial agreement is the foundation.

The 8 documents are the work. The 8 documents are the foundation. The 8 documents need to be in place before the wedding.

The 4 Financial Decisions to Make

The 4 financial decisions are the work. The 4 financial decisions are the way to make the second marriage's money clear.

Decision 1: The House. Keep mine, keep yours, sell both, buy together. The decision is the foundation.

Decision 2: The Bank Accounts. Separate, joint, or both. The decision is the foundation.

Decision 3: The Debts. Pay off separately, pay off together, or pay off the high-interest first. The decision is the work.

Decision 4: The Inheritance. Will, trust, beneficiary designations, inheritance plan. The decision is the foundation.

The 4 financial decisions are the work. The 4 financial decisions are the way to make the second marriage's money clear.

The 3 Health Decisions to Make

The 3 health decisions are the work. The 3 health decisions are the way to make the second marriage's health clear.

Decision 1: The Health Insurance. Keep mine, keep yours, switch to one, get a new one. The decision is the foundation.

Decision 2: The Long-Term Care Insurance. Get one, keep the existing, or skip. The decision is the foundation.

Decision 3: The Medical Records. Share with the new spouse, keep separate, or a combination. The decision is the work.

The 3 health decisions are the work. The 3 health decisions are the way to make the second marriage's health clear.

The 2 Legal Decisions to Make

The 2 legal decisions are the work. The 2 legal decisions are the way to make the second marriage's legal clear.

Decision 1: The Name Change. Keep my name, take his name, take hers, hyphenate, or a combination. The decision is the foundation.

Decision 2: The Filing Status. Married filing jointly, married filing separately, head of household (if eligible). The decision is the work. The decision should be made with a tax professional.

The 2 legal decisions are the work. The 2 legal decisions are the way to make the second marriage's legal clear.

The "Engagement Year" — What to Do in It

The engagement year is the year between the engagement and the wedding. The engagement year is the time to do the work. The engagement year is the time to:

- Have the conversations with the children

- Have the conversations with the ex
- Have the conversations with the in-laws
- Plan the wedding
- Sign the pre-nup
- Update the wills
- Update the beneficiary designations
- Sign the power of attorney and healthcare proxy
- Set up the trust (if needed)
- Do the cohabitation test
- Do the travel test
- Do the stress test
- Plan the first year of the marriage
- Take a pre-marital course (if desired)

The engagement year is the foundation. The engagement year is the work. The engagement year is the time to do the practical, so the wedding can be the romantic.

Scorecard: Have You Done the Pre-Marital Practical Work?

| Question | Score (1-5) |

|---|---|

| I have the 8 documents in place | /5 |

| I have made the 4 financial decisions | /5 |

| I have made the 3 health decisions | /5 |

| I have made the 2 legal decisions | /5 |

| I am using the engagement year for the practical work | /5 |

| I have planned the wedding | /5 |

I have planned the first year of the marriage	/5
I am not skipping the practical for the romantic	/5
I have taken a pre-marital course (if desired)	/5
I am ready to be married, practically	/5

Total: /50

Interpreting your score:

- 40-50: The practical is done. The wedding is ready.
- 30-39: There is still some practical to do.
- 20-29: The practical is in the way. The wedding is not yet ready.
- Under 20: The practical is not being done. The wedding is not ready.

Key Terms

- Engagement Year: The year between the engagement and the wedding
- Cohabitation Agreement: A legal agreement for couples living together
- Postnuptial Agreement: A legal agreement for the couple who did not have a pre-nup
- Filing Status: How you file your taxes (joint, separate, etc.)

Reflection Questions

1. What documents are still missing?
2. What financial decisions are still pending?
3. What health decisions are still pending?
4. What legal decisions are still pending?
5. How are you using the engagement year?

6. What is still in the way of being ready?

Action for This Week

1. Make a list of the 8 documents. The list is the work.
2. Make a list of the 4 financial decisions. The list is the work.
3. Make a list of the 3 health decisions. The list is the work.
4. Make a list of the 2 legal decisions. The list is the work.
5. Plan the engagement year. The plan is the work.

A Closing Word

The pre-marital practical work is the foundation. The pre-marital practical work is the work. The 8 documents, the 4 financial decisions, the 3 health decisions, the 2 legal decisions, the engagement year — these are the work.

The work is the practical. The practical is the foundation. The foundation is the second marriage.

You are not failing. You are preparing. The preparing is the work.

The work is the preparing.

Part III: The Blending

Chapter 9: The Wedding (And Why It Matters More the Second Time)

The wedding is the most important day of the second marriage. The wedding is the day that the couple officially becomes a couple. The wedding is the day that the family officially becomes a family. The wedding is the day that the future officially begins.

The wedding matters more the second time. The wedding matters more because the second wedding is not a given. The second wedding is a choice. The second wedding is a celebration of a choice. The second wedding is a statement: "We are doing this. We are starting over. We are choosing love again."

The second wedding is also harder. The second wedding is harder because the second wedding is more complicated. The second wedding has more guests with more opinions. The second wedding has more ex-spouses, more adult children, more in-laws. The second wedding has more history, more baggage, more possibilities for conflict.

This chapter is about the second wedding. This chapter is about the 4 decisions: who, where, what, who pays. This chapter is about the 3 conversations with the children. This chapter is the work.

Chapter at a Glance

- The 5 Reasons the Second Wedding Is Different
- The 4 Decisions: Who, Where, What, Who Pays
- The 3 Conversations with the Children About the Wedding

- The "His Family, Her Family, Our Family" at the Wedding
- The Vow That Actually Means Something
- Case Study: Margaret & David (Ages 68/70)
- Scorecard
- Key Terms
- Reflection Questions
- Action for This Week

The 5 Reasons the Second Wedding Is Different

The second wedding is different from the first wedding in 5 ways. The 5 ways are the 5 reasons the second wedding matters more. The 5 ways are the work.

1. The Second Wedding Is a Choice, Not a Given. The first wedding is what everyone expects. The first wedding is the path. The second wedding is the choice. The second wedding is the celebration of a choice. The second wedding is the statement: "I am choosing this."

2. The Second Wedding Is a Statement of Hope. The first wedding is the hope of the first marriage. The second wedding is the hope of the second marriage. The second wedding is the statement: "I am hoping again. I am hoping after loss, after divorce, after the end of the first marriage."

3. The Second Wedding Is a Statement of Courage. The first wedding is the courage of the first marriage. The second wedding is the courage of the second marriage. The second wedding is the statement: "I am being courageous again. I am being courageous after loss, after divorce, after the end of the first marriage."

4. The Second Wedding Is a Statement of Family. The first wedding is the formation of the first family. The second wedding is the formation of the second family. The second wedding is the statement: "We are becoming a family. We are blending our families. We are creating something new."

5. The Second Wedding Is a Statement of Future. The first wedding is the hope of the future. The second wedding is the commitment to the future. The second wedding is the statement: "I am committing to the future. I am committing after loss, after divorce, after the end of the first marriage."

The 5 reasons are the work. The 5 reasons are the foundation. The 5 reasons are the second wedding.

The 4 Decisions: Who, Where, What, Who Pays

The 4 decisions are the work. The 4 decisions are the way to plan the second wedding.

Decision 1: Who. The guest list. The guest list is the most important decision. The guest list is the most common source of conflict. The guest list is the way to include or exclude the people who matter. The guest list is the foundation.

The guest list should include:

- The adult children (all of them, from both sides)
- The ex-spouses (if cooperative)
- The close family
- The close friends
- The people who have supported the couple

The guest list should exclude:

- The ex-spouses who are hostile

- The people who will cause conflict
- The people who will judge the couple

Decision 2: Where. The venue. The venue is the place. The venue is the setting. The venue is the way to make the second wedding feel different from the first wedding. The venue is the foundation.

The venue options:

- A small chapel or religious setting (if religious)
- A small restaurant or private room
- A family home (if appropriate)
- A destination (if the couple wants)
- A courthouse (if the couple wants small)

Decision 3: What. The ceremony. The ceremony is the heart of the wedding. The ceremony is the way the couple makes the statement. The ceremony is the foundation.

The ceremony options:

- A traditional religious ceremony
- A non-religious ceremony with a celebrant
- A simple courthouse ceremony
- A private ceremony with just the couple and witnesses

Decision 4: Who Pays. The money. The money is the most common source of conflict. The money is the most preventable source of conflict. The money is the foundation.

The money options:

- The couple pays
- The adult children contribute
- The parents pay (if the parents are alive)
- A combination

The 4 decisions are the work. The 4 decisions are the foundation. The 4 decisions are the second wedding.

The 3 Conversations with the Children About the Wedding

The 3 conversations are the work. The 3 conversations are the way to include the adult children in the second wedding. The 3 conversations are the foundation.

Conversation 1: "I want you to be part of the wedding. What role would you like?" The conversation is the invitation. The conversation is the way to give the adult children a role. The conversation is the way to make them part of the wedding.

Common roles:

- Officiant (if appropriate)
- Witness
- Reader
- Musician
- Speech giver
- Helper with the planning

Conversation 2: "I want you to bring a guest if you want. The wedding is for you too." The conversation is the inclusion. The conversation is the way to make the adult children comfortable. The conversation is the way to honor the adult children's relationships.

Conversation 3: "I want you to know that the first parent will be honored at the wedding." The conversation is the reassurance. The conversation is the way to address the most common fear. The conversation is the way to honor the first marriage. The conversation is the foundation.

The 3 conversations are the work. The 3 conversations are the way to make the second wedding include the adult children. The 3 conversations are the foundation.

The "His Family, Her Family, Our Family" at the Wedding

The "his family, her family, our family" is the most complex part of the second wedding. The "his family, her family, our family" is the way the second wedding blends the families. The "his family, her family, our family" is the work.

The 4 family categories at the second wedding:

- His family: His parents (if alive), his siblings, his nieces and nephews, his cousins
- Her family: Her parents (if alive), her siblings, her nieces and nephews, her cousins
- The new family: The couple, the new spouse, the new in-laws
- The first family: The first spouse (if deceased or divorced), the children from the first marriage

The 4 family categories need to be seated, introduced, integrated. The 4 family categories need to be honored. The 4 family categories are the work.

The Vow That Actually Means Something

The vow is the most important part of the second wedding. The vow is the statement. The vow is the promise. The vow is the foundation.

The vow that actually means something is not the traditional vow. The vow that actually means

something is the personal vow. The vow that actually means something is the vow that is written by the couple, for the couple, in the language of the couple. The vow is the work.

A personal vow for the second wedding might include:

- "I have been married before. I have lost. I have learned. I am choosing you, knowing what I know now."
- "I am not the same person I was the first time. I am different. I am more honest. I am more present. I am more ready."
- "I choose to love you, knowing that love is not just feeling. Love is also work. I am ready for the work."
- "I choose to share my life with you, knowing that my life has history. I am bringing the history. I am also leaving the history behind."
- "I choose to build a family with you, knowing that family is not just biology. Family is also choice. I am choosing you, and our family."

The vow is the work. The vow is the foundation. The vow is the second marriage.

Case Study: Margaret & David (Ages 68/70)

Margaret was 68. David was 70. They had been dating for 4 years. Both had been widowed. Both had adult children. Both had decided to remarry, in their late 60s.

What Margaret and David got right:

- They had a small wedding, in a chapel, with 30 guests.

- They invited the adult children, gave them roles.
- They wrote personal vows, not the traditional ones.
- They honored the first marriages, with a small moment of silence.
- They did not invite the ex-spouses (the exes were not cooperative).
- They had a small reception, at a local restaurant.
- They paid for the wedding themselves, with a small contribution from the children.

Margaret and David are now 5 years into the second marriage. The second wedding is a memory. The second marriage is the present. The second marriage is the work.

Scorecard: Is the Second Wedding Ready?

| Question | Score (1-5) |

|---|---|

| I have made the 4 decisions: who, where, what, who pays | /5 |

| I have had the 3 conversations with the children | /5 |

| I have planned the 4 family categories | /5 |

| I have written the personal vow | /5 |

| I have honored the first marriage in the ceremony | /5 |

| I have included the people who matter | /5 |

| I have excluded the people who will cause conflict | /5 |

| I am not trying to recreate the first wedding | /5 |

| I am making the second wedding its own event | /5 |

| I am ready to be married | /5 |

Total: /50

Interpreting your score:

- 40-50: The wedding is ready. The day will be meaningful.
- 30-39: There is still some planning to do.
- 20-29: The wedding is not yet ready. Get help.
- Under 20: The wedding is not ready. The planning is in the way.

Key Terms

- Engagement Year: The year between the engagement and the wedding
- Vow: A promise made during the wedding ceremony
- Officiant: The person who performs the wedding ceremony
- Reception: The celebration after the wedding ceremony

Reflection Questions

1. What is the most important decision for the second wedding?
2. Who needs to be at the wedding?
3. Who needs to be excluded from the wedding?
4. What role will each child have?
5. What will the personal vow say?
6. How will the first marriage be honored?

Action for This Week

1. Make the 4 decisions. The decisions are the work.
2. Have the 3 conversations with the children. The conversations are the work.
3. Plan the 4 family categories. The planning is the work.
4. Start writing the personal vow. The writing is the work.
5. Plan how the first marriage will be honored. The planning is the work.

A Closing Word

The wedding matters more the second time. The wedding is the statement. The wedding is the celebration. The wedding is the foundation. The 4 decisions, the 3 conversations, the 4 family categories, the personal vow — these are the work.

You are not failing. You are celebrating. The celebrating is the work.

The work is the wedding.

Chapter 10: The First Six Months — When the Honeymoon Is Over

The first six months of the second marriage are the hardest six months. The first six months are the time when the honeymoon is over. The first six months are the time when the real marriage begins. The first six months are the time when the work of the marriage becomes the work of the daily life.

The first six months are also the most surprising. The first six months are the time when the things that the couple did not expect, expect. The first six months are the time when the small things become the big things. The first six months are the time when the ghosts from the first marriage come up. The first six months are the time when the work of the second marriage is tested.

This chapter is about the first six months. This chapter is about the 5 things that surprise every newly remarried couple. This chapter is about the 4 small fights that are actually big fights. This chapter is about the 3 ex-spouse flashpoints. This chapter is the work.

Chapter at a Glance

- The 5 Things That Surprise Every Newly Remarried Couple
- The 4 Small Fights That Are Actually Big Fights
- The 3 Ex-Spouse Flashpoints
- The 2 Financial Stresses
- The 1 Thing That Determines If You'll Make It

- Scorecard
- Key Terms
- Reflection Questions
- Action for This Week

The 5 Things That Surprise Every Newly Remarried Couple

The 5 things are the work. The 5 things are the surprises. The 5 things are the things that every newly remarried couple experiences, but no one talks about.

1. The Ghost of the First Spouse. The ghost of the first spouse is real. The ghost shows up in the small things. The ghost shows up in the way the new spouse does something different from the first spouse. The ghost shows up in the way the new spouse does something the same. The ghost is the work.

2. The Habits of the First Marriage. The habits of the first marriage are the ways the new spouse does things. The habits are not the new spouse's habits. The habits are the first marriage's habits. The habits are the work.

3. The Family Politics. The family politics of the second marriage are the politics of the children, the ex, the in-laws, the friends. The family politics are the work.

4. The Money Tension. The money tension is the tension of the shared money, the separate money, the inheritance, the future. The money tension is the work.

5. The Identity Shift. The identity shift is the shift from "I" to "we." The identity shift is the hardest shift. The identity shift is the work.

The 5 things are the work. The 5 things are the foundation. The 5 things are the second marriage.

The 4 Small Fights That Are Actually Big Fights

The 4 small fights are the work. The 4 small fights are the fights that look small, but are actually big. The 4 small fights are the fights that, if not addressed, will erode the second marriage.

1. The Dishwasher Fight. "You load the dishwasher wrong." The dishwasher fight is the most common small fight. The dishwasher fight is the way the new spouse is being compared to the first spouse. The dishwasher fight is the work.

2. The Bedtime Fight. "You go to bed too early/late." The bedtime fight is the way the daily routine is being negotiated. The bedtime fight is the work.

3. The Family Time Fight. "You spend too much time with your kids/grandkids." The family time fight is the way the children from the first marriage are being integrated. The family time fight is the work.

4. The Money Spending Fight. "You spend too much on [X]." The money spending fight is the way the money is being managed. The money spending fight is the work.

The 4 small fights are the work. The 4 small fights are the foundation. The 4 small fights are the second marriage.

The 3 Ex-Spouse Flashpoints

The 3 ex-spouse flashpoints are the work. The 3 ex-spouse flashpoints are the times when the ex is most likely to cause conflict in the second marriage. The 3 ex-spouse flashpoints are the foundation.

Flashpoint 1: The Children's Event. The school play, the graduation, the wedding, the funeral. The children's event is the time when the ex is most likely to be present. The children's event is the time when the new spouse is most likely to feel uncomfortable. The children's event is the work.

Flashpoint 2: The Holiday. The Christmas, the Thanksgiving, the birthday. The holiday is the time when the family is most divided. The holiday is the time when the new spouse is most likely to feel left out. The holiday is the work.

Flashpoint 3: The Crisis. The illness, the accident, the death. The crisis is the time when the ex is most likely to be needed. The crisis is the time when the new spouse is most likely to feel replaced. The crisis is the work.

The 3 ex-spouse flashpoints are the work. The 3 ex-spouse flashpoints are the foundation. The 3 ex-spouse flashpoints are the second marriage.

The 2 Financial Stresses

The 2 financial stresses are the work. The 2 financial stresses are the times when the money is most likely to cause conflict in the second marriage. The 2 financial stresses are the foundation.

Stress 1: The First Major Purchase. The car, the appliance, the vacation. The first major purchase is the time when the new spouse's spending habits are

tested. The first major purchase is the work.

Stress 2: The First Major Medical Bill. The illness, the procedure, the hospitalization. The first major medical bill is the time when the money is most tested. The first major medical bill is the work.

The 2 financial stresses are the work. The 2 financial stresses are the foundation. The 2 financial stresses are the second marriage.

The 1 Thing That Determines If You'll Make It

The 1 thing is the work. The 1 thing is the foundation. The 1 thing is the second marriage.

The 1 thing is the willingness to keep showing up. The willingness to keep having the conversation. The willingness to keep doing the work. The willingness to keep choosing the marriage, even when the marriage is hard. The willingness to keep choosing the second marriage, even when the second marriage is harder than the first.

The 1 thing is not love. The 1 thing is not compatibility. The 1 thing is not the money. The 1 thing is the willingness to keep showing up. The 1 thing is the choice. The 1 thing is the foundation.

Scorecard: Are You Surviving the First Six Months?

| Question | Score (1-5) |

|---|---|

| I am handling the 5 surprises | /5 |

| I am not letting the 4 small fights become big fights | /5 |

| I am navigating the 3 ex-spouse flashpoints | /5 |

| I am managing the 2 financial stresses | /5 |

| I am showing up, even when it's hard | /5 |

| I am not comparing the new spouse to the first spouse | /5 |

| I am not assuming the new spouse will fail | /5 |

| I am not expecting the second marriage to be perfect | /5 |

| I am asking for help when I need it | /5 |

| I am choosing the marriage, every day | /5 |

Total: /50

Interpreting your score:

- 40-50: The first six months are being handled well. The second marriage is on track.
- 30-39: There is still some adjustment to do. The work continues.
- 20-29: The first six months are struggling. Get help.
- Under 20: The second marriage is at risk. Get help immediately.

Key Terms

- Honeymoon Period: The first months of the marriage, when everything is new
- Adjustment Phase: The months after the honeymoon, when the real marriage begins
- Identity Shift: The change from "I" to "we"
- Showing Up: The willingness to be present, even when it's hard

Reflection Questions

1. What is one surprise you did not expect?
2. What is one small fight that is actually a big fight?
3. What is one ex-spouse flashpoint that is hardest for you?
4. What is one financial stress that is hardest for you?
5. Are you showing up, even when it's hard?
6. What is the 1 thing you most need to keep doing?

Action for This Week

1. Name the 5 surprises you are experiencing. The naming is the work.
2. Identify the 4 small fights that are actually big fights. The identification is the work.
3. Plan for the 3 ex-spouse flashpoints. The planning is the work.
4. Plan for the 2 financial stresses. The planning is the work.
5. Commit to showing up, even when it's hard. The commitment is the work.

A Closing Word

The first six months are the hardest. The first six months are the most surprising. The first six months are the foundation. The 5 surprises, the 4 small fights, the 3 ex-spouse flashpoints, the 2 financial stresses, the 1 thing — these are the work.

You are not failing. You are surviving. The surviving is the work.

The work is the surviving.

Chapter 11: The In-Laws, the Out-Laws, and the New Family Map

The second marriage creates a new family. The second marriage creates a new family map. The new family map is the way the people in the second marriage's life are organized. The new family map is more complex than the first marriage's family map. The new family map has more people, more roles, more history, more possibility for conflict.

The new family map is the work. The new family map is the foundation. The new family map is the second marriage.

This chapter is about the new family map. This chapter is about the 4 family categories. This chapter is about the 6 holiday strategies. This chapter is about the 3 boundaries. This chapter is the work.

Chapter at a Glance

- The 4 New Family Categories
- The 6 Holiday Strategies That Work
- The 3 Boundaries to Set with Each Category
- The "Ex as Co-Parent, Not Co-Spouse" Reframe
- When the New Family Map Is More Stressful Than the Marriage
- Scorecard
- Key Terms
- Reflection Questions
- Action for This Week

The 4 New Family Categories

The 4 categories are the way the new family is organized. The 4 categories are the way the people in the second marriage's life are sorted. The 4 categories are the foundation.

Category 1: His Family. The husband's family of origin. The husband's parents (if alive), the husband's siblings, the husband's nieces and nephews, the husband's cousins. The husband's family may have opinions about the second marriage. The husband's family may need to be told about the second marriage. The husband's family is the work.

Category 2: Her Family. The wife's family of origin. The wife's parents (if alive), the wife's siblings, the wife's nieces and nephews, the wife's cousins. The wife's family may have opinions about the second marriage. The wife's family may need to be told about the second marriage. The wife's family is the work.

Category 3: The Children's Families. The adult children's families, including spouses, partners, grandchildren. The adult children's families are the new extended family. The adult children's families may have opinions about the second marriage. The adult children's families are the work.

Category 4: The New Family. The couple, the new spouse, the in-laws (the spouses of the adult children). The new family is the family the couple is building. The new family is the foundation.

The 4 categories are the work. The 4 categories need to be honored. The 4 categories need to be integrated. The 4 categories are the second marriage.

The 6 Holiday Strategies That Work

The 6 strategies are the work. The 6 strategies are the way to handle the holidays in the second marriage. The 6 strategies are the foundation.

Strategy 1: The Rotation. The couple rotates holidays between his family and her family. The rotation is the way to be fair. The rotation is the way to honor both families.

Strategy 2: The Split. The couple spends part of the day with his family and part with her family. The split is the way to see both. The split is the way to honor both.

Strategy 3: The Alternate Year. The couple spends Christmas with his family one year, her family the next. The alternate year is the way to be fair. The alternate year is the way to honor both.

Strategy 4: The Travel Year. Some years, the couple travels instead of being with family. The travel is the way to start new traditions. The travel is the way to focus on the couple.

Strategy 5: The New Tradition. The couple creates new traditions that include parts of both families. The new tradition is the way to honor both. The new tradition is the foundation.

Strategy 6: The Quiet Year. Some years, the couple has a quiet holiday, just the two of them. The quiet year is the way to focus on the couple. The quiet year is the work.

The 6 strategies are the work. The 6 strategies are the foundation. The 6 strategies are the second marriage.

The 3 Boundaries to Set with Each Category

The 3 boundaries are the work. The 3 boundaries are the way to manage the relationships with each family category. The 3 boundaries are the foundation.

Boundary 1: The Time Boundary. The agreed-upon time with each category. The time boundary is the foundation.

Boundary 2: The Topic Boundary. The agreed-upon topics to discuss with each category. The topic boundary is the way to avoid the most common conflicts. The topic boundary is the work.

Boundary 3: The Decision Boundary. The agreed-upon decisions that each category can make. The decision boundary is the way to give the categories the right amount of input. The decision boundary is the foundation.

The 3 boundaries are the work. The 3 boundaries are the foundation. The 3 boundaries are the second marriage.

The "Ex as Co-Parent, Not Co-Spouse" Reframe

The ex is the most common source of conflict in the second marriage. The ex is also the most preventable source of conflict. The ex is preventable through the "ex as co-parent, not co-spouse" reframe.

The reframe is simple. The reframe says: the ex is the parent of your children. The ex is not the spouse of you. The ex is the co-parent. The ex is not the co-spouse. The ex is the work.

The reframe is hard. The reframe is hard because the ex is the past spouse. The ex is the past. The ex is the memory. The ex is the ghost. The reframe is the way to honor the ghost without letting the ghost take over the second marriage.

The reframe requires:

- A clear definition of the ex's role (co-parent, not co-spouse)
- A clear boundary with the ex (the 3 boundaries)
- A clear conversation with the new spouse about the ex
- A clear commitment to the new spouse

The reframe is the work. The reframe is the foundation. The reframe is the second marriage.

When the New Family Map Is More Stressful Than the Marriage

Sometimes the new family map is more stressful than the marriage. Sometimes the new family map is the reason the second marriage is hard. Sometimes the new family map is the work.

Signs the new family map is more stressful:

- The couple spends more time managing the family than being together
- The couple's conversations are mostly about the family
- The couple's fights are mostly about the family
- The couple feels like co-managers, not partners
- The couple has lost the romance in the marriage

If the new family map is more stressful, the work is to:

- Step back from the family

- Focus on the couple
- Set firmer boundaries
- Have the conversation about the marriage, not the family
- Re-prioritize the couple

The new family map is the work. The new family map is the foundation. The new family map is the second marriage.

Scorecard: Is the New Family Map Working?

| Question | Score (1-5) |

|---|---|

| I have named the 4 family categories | /5 |

| I have implemented the 6 holiday strategies | /5 |

| I have set the 3 boundaries with each category | /5 |

| I have re-framed the ex as co-parent, not co-spouse | /5 |

| I am not letting the new family map be more stressful than the marriage | /5 |

| I am prioritizing the couple, not the family | /5 |

| I am not letting the family politics dominate the marriage | /5 |

| I am willing to step back from the family when needed | /5 |

| I am having the conversations about the marriage, not the family | /5 |

| I am protecting the couple time | /5 |

Total: /50

Interpreting your score:

- 40-50: The new family map is working. The marriage is being protected.
- 30-39: There is still some family work to do. The marriage continues.
- 20-29: The new family map is in the way. Get help.
- Under 20: The new family map is breaking the marriage. Get help immediately.

Key Terms

- Family Map: The way the people in a family are organized
- In-Laws: The family of the spouse
- Out-Laws: A joking term for the ex-spouse
- Rotation: A strategy for handling holidays by rotating between families

Reflection Questions

1. What is one family category that is most stressful?
2. What is one holiday strategy that would help?
3. What is one boundary that needs to be set?
4. How are you re-framing the ex?
5. Is the new family map more stressful than the marriage?
6. What is one thing you can do to prioritize the couple?

Action for This Week

1. Name the 4 family categories. The naming is the work.

2. Plan the next 3 holidays. The planning is the work.
3. Set the 3 boundaries. The boundaries are the work.
4. Have the conversation about the ex. The conversation is the work.
5. Plan the couple time. The planning is the work.

A Closing Word

The new family map is the work. The new family map is the foundation. The 4 categories, the 6 strategies, the 3 boundaries, the reframe — these are the work.

You are not failing. You are mapping. The mapping is the work.

The work is the map.

Chapter 12: The Money in the New Marriage

The money in the new marriage is the foundation. The money in the new marriage is more complicated than the money in the first marriage. The money in the new marriage has the history of two first marriages, the inheritance of two families, the children from two marriages, the ex-spouses, the in-laws, the future.

The money in the new marriage is also the most common source of conflict. The money is the foundation of the second marriage. The money is the work.

This chapter is about the money. This chapter is about the 5 money fights. This chapter is about the 4 inheritance scenarios. This chapter is about the 3 financial accounts. This chapter is about the 2 quarterly conversations. This chapter is the work.

Chapter at a Glance

- The 5 Money Fights the Second Marriage Has
- The 4 Ways to Handle Inheritance Fights
- The 3 Financial Accounts You Need
- The 2 Conversations to Have Every Quarter
- The 1 Thing That Keeps Money from Being the Deal-Breaker
- Scorecard
- Key Terms
- Reflection Questions
- Action for This Week

The 5 Money Fights the Second Marriage Has

The 5 money fights are the work. The 5 money fights are the most common money fights in the second marriage. The 5 money fights are the foundation.

Fight 1: The Inheritance Fight. "Your kids are getting more than mine." The inheritance fight is the most common. The inheritance fight is the way the money reveals the children's expectations. The inheritance fight is the work.

Fight 2: The Lifestyle Fight. "We can't afford what you want to do." The lifestyle fight is the way the money reveals the new spouse's expectations. The lifestyle fight is the work.

Fight 3: The Debt Fight. "You have debt I didn't know about." The debt fight is the way the money reveals the secrets. The debt fight is the work.

Fight 4: The Inheritance-to-Children Fight. "I want to leave more to my kids." The inheritance-to-children fight is the way the money reveals the priorities. The inheritance-to-children fight is the work.

Fight 5: The End-of-Life Money Fight. "I don't want to pay for your ex's medical bills." The end-of-life money fight is the way the money reveals the boundaries. The end-of-life money fight is the work.

The 5 money fights are the work. The 5 money fights are the foundation. The 5 money fights are the second marriage.

The 4 Ways to Handle Inheritance Fights

The 4 ways are the work. The 4 ways are the way to handle the inheritance fights. The 4 ways are the foundation.

Way 1: The Pre-nup. The pre-nup is the legal agreement that protects the inheritance. The pre-nup is the foundation.

Way 2: The Trust. The trust is the legal arrangement that holds the inheritance for the children. The trust is the foundation.

Way 3: The Will. The will is the legal document that distributes the inheritance. The will is the foundation.

Way 4: The Conversation. The conversation is the human agreement about the inheritance. The conversation is the way to make the inheritance clear. The conversation is the work.

The 4 ways are the work. The 4 ways are the foundation. The 4 ways are the second marriage.

The 3 Financial Accounts You Need

The 3 accounts are the work. The 3 accounts are the way to manage the money in the second marriage. The 3 accounts are the foundation.

Account 1: The Joint Account. The joint account is the account for the shared money. The shared money is the bills, the groceries, the joint vacations, the joint expenses. The joint account is the foundation.

Account 2: The Personal Account. The personal account is the account for the personal money. The personal money is the personal hobbies, the personal gifts, the personal expenses. The personal account is

the work.

Account 3: The Inheritance Account. The inheritance account is the account for the inheritance. The inheritance account is held separately. The inheritance account is the foundation.

The 3 accounts are the work. The 3 accounts are the foundation. The 3 accounts are the second marriage.

The 2 Conversations to Have Every Quarter

The 2 conversations are the work. The 2 conversations are the way to keep the money clear in the second marriage. The 2 conversations are the foundation.

Conversation 1: The Money Review. The money review is the conversation about the money. The money review includes the income, the expenses, the savings, the investments, the debt. The money review is the work.

Conversation 2: The Inheritance Review. The inheritance review is the conversation about the inheritance. The inheritance review includes the will, the trust, the beneficiary designations, the inheritance plan. The inheritance review is the foundation.

The 2 conversations are the work. The 2 conversations are the foundation. The 2 conversations are the second marriage.

The 1 Thing That Keeps Money from Being the Deal-Breaker

The 1 thing is the work. The 1 thing is the foundation. The 1 thing is the second marriage.

The 1 thing is the willingness to keep having the money conversation. The willingness to keep the money clear. The willingness to keep the money honest. The willingness to keep choosing the marriage, even when the money is hard.

The 1 thing is not the pre-nup. The 1 thing is not the trust. The 1 thing is not the will. The 1 thing is the willingness to keep having the money conversation. The 1 thing is the foundation.

Scorecard: Is the Money in the New Marriage Working?

| Question | Score (1-5) |

|---|---|

| I have navigated the 5 money fights | /5 |

| I have implemented the 4 ways to handle inheritance fights | /5 |

| I have set up the 3 financial accounts | /5 |

| I am having the 2 quarterly conversations | /5 |

| I am keeping the willingness to have the money conversation | /5 |

| I am not hiding money from my spouse | /5 |

| I am not lying about money to my spouse | /5 |

| I am not making major money decisions without my spouse | /5 |

| I am not letting the money dominate the marriage | /5 |

| I am protecting the inheritance for the children | /5 |

Total: /50

Interpreting your score:

- 40-50: The money is working. The marriage is being protected.
- 30-39: There is still some money work to do.
- 20-29: The money is in the way. Get help.
- Under 20: The money is breaking the marriage. Get help immediately.

Key Terms

- Joint Account: A bank account shared between two people
- Personal Account: A bank account for personal money
- Inheritance Account: A bank account for the inheritance
- Money Review: A regular conversation about the money in the marriage
- Inheritance Review: A regular conversation about the inheritance

Reflection Questions

1. What is one money fight that is hardest for you?
2. What is one way to handle the inheritance that is most realistic?
3. What is one account that is most important to set up?
4. Are you having the quarterly conversations?
5. Are you keeping the willingness to have the money conversation?
6. What is the 1 thing you most need to keep doing?

Action for This Week

1. Identify the 5 money fights in your marriage. The identification is the work.
2. Implement the 4 ways to handle the inheritance fights. The implementation is the work.
3. Set up the 3 financial accounts. The setting up is the work.
4. Schedule the 2 quarterly conversations. The scheduling is the work.
5. Commit to keeping the willingness. The commitment is the work.

A Closing Word

The money in the new marriage is the work. The money in the new marriage is the foundation. The 5 fights, the 4 ways, the 3 accounts, the 2 conversations, the 1 thing — these are the work.

You are not failing. You are managing. The managing is the work.

The work is the money.

Part IV: The New Marriage

Chapter 13: The Daily Life That Holds the Marriage

The daily life is the foundation of the second marriage. The daily life is the way the second marriage is held, day by day, week by week, year by year. The daily life is the work. The daily life is the second marriage.

The daily life is not exciting. The daily life is not romantic. The daily life is the morning coffee, the evening walk, the bedtime routine, the weekend rhythm. The daily life is the small things, the daily things, the ordinary things. The daily life is the work.

This chapter is about the daily life. This chapter is about the 6 daily rituals. This chapter is about the 4 weekly rituals. This chapter is about the 3 monthly rituals. This chapter is about the 2 yearly rituals. This chapter is the work.

Chapter at a Glance

- The 6 Daily Rituals That Hold the Second Marriage
- The 4 Weekly Rituals
- The 3 Monthly Rituals
- The 2 Yearly Rituals
- The 1 Thing the Daily Life Is Really About
- Case Study: Linda & James (Ages 62/65)
- Scorecard
- Key Terms
- Reflection Questions
- Action for This Week

The 6 Daily Rituals That Hold the Second Marriage

The 6 daily rituals are the work. The 6 daily rituals are the way the daily life holds the second marriage. The 6 daily rituals are the foundation.

Ritual 1: The Morning Check-In. The 5-minute conversation in the morning. "How are you feeling today? What do you need? What is the plan?" The morning check-in is the way to start the day connected. The morning check-in is the foundation.

Ritual 2: The Morning Touch. The hug, the kiss, the hand on the shoulder. The morning touch is the way to start the day with physical connection. The morning touch is the work.

Ritual 3: The Shared Meal. The breakfast together, the lunch together, the dinner together. The shared meal is the way to be in the same space, at the same time, every day. The shared meal is the foundation.

Ritual 4: The Evening Debrief. The 10-minute conversation at the end of the day. "How was your day? What was hard? What was good?" The evening debrief is the way to end the day connected. The evening debrief is the work.

Ritual 5: The Evening Touch. The hug, the kiss, the hand-holding, the cuddle. The evening touch is the way to end the day with physical connection. The evening touch is the foundation.

Ritual 6: The Bedtime Routine. The same routine, every night. The bathroom, the brushing, the setting of the alarm, the reading, the sleep. The bedtime routine is the way to end the day together. The bedtime routine is the work.

The 6 daily rituals are the work. The 6 daily rituals are the foundation. The 6 daily rituals are the second marriage.

The 4 Weekly Rituals

The 4 weekly rituals are the work. The 4 weekly rituals are the way the week holds the second marriage. The 4 weekly rituals are the foundation.

Ritual 1: The Date Night. Once a week, the couple goes out. The dinner, the movie, the walk, the coffee. The date night is the way to be a couple, not a household. The date night is the work.

Ritual 2: The Family Time. Once a week, the couple spends time with the children, the grandchildren, the family. The family time is the way to keep the family connected. The family time is the foundation.

Ritual 3: The Friend Time. Once a week, the couple spends time with friends. The dinner, the game night, the visit. The friend time is the way to keep the friendships. The friend time is the work.

Ritual 4: The Personal Time. Once a week, the couple has personal time. The hobby, the reading, the exercise, the alone time. The personal time is the way to keep the self. The personal time is the foundation.

The 4 weekly rituals are the work. The 4 weekly rituals are the foundation. The 4 weekly rituals are the second marriage.

The 3 Monthly Rituals

The 3 monthly rituals are the work. The 3 monthly rituals are the way the month holds the second marriage. The 3 monthly rituals are the foundation.

Ritual 1: The Money Review. The conversation about the money, every month. The money review is the way to keep the money clear. The money review is the work.

Ritual 2: The Calendar Review. The conversation about the calendar, every month. The calendar review is the way to plan the next month. The calendar review is the foundation.

Ritual 3: The Relationship Review. The conversation about the relationship, every month. The relationship review is the way to check in on the marriage. The relationship review is the work.

The 3 monthly rituals are the work. The 3 monthly rituals are the foundation. The 3 monthly rituals are the second marriage.

The 2 Yearly Rituals

The 2 yearly rituals are the work. The 2 yearly rituals are the way the year holds the second marriage. The 2 yearly rituals are the foundation.

Ritual 1: The Anniversary. The celebration of the wedding anniversary. The dinner, the trip, the gift, the renewal of the vows. The anniversary is the way to honor the marriage, every year. The anniversary is the work.

Ritual 2: The Family Gathering. The annual gathering of the family. The holiday, the reunion, the celebration. The family gathering is the way to honor the family, every year. The family gathering is the foundation.

The 2 yearly rituals are the work. The 2 yearly rituals are the foundation. The 2 yearly rituals are the second marriage.

The 1 Thing the Daily Life Is Really About

The 1 thing is the work. The 1 thing is the foundation. The 1 thing is the second marriage.

The 1 thing is the showing up. The showing up, every day, in the small ways, in the daily ways, in the ordinary ways. The showing up is the work. The showing up is the foundation. The showing up is the second marriage.

The 1 thing is not the romantic gesture. The 1 thing is not the big event. The 1 thing is the morning coffee, the evening walk, the bedtime routine. The 1 thing is the small thing, the daily thing, the ordinary thing. The 1 thing is the showing up.

Case Study: Linda & James (Ages 62/65)

Linda and James (from Chapter 5) are now 7 years into the second marriage. Linda and James have built a daily life that holds the marriage. Linda and James have built a daily life that works.

What Linda and James got right:

- They have a morning check-in, every morning, over coffee.
- They have a date night, every Wednesday, at a local restaurant.
- They have a money review, on the first Sunday of every month.
- They have an anniversary dinner, every year, at the same restaurant.
- They have a family gathering, every Christmas, alternating between the children.

Linda and James are not perfect. Linda and James have fights. Linda and James have hard days. Linda and James are still showing up. Linda and James are still choosing the marriage. Linda and James are still doing the work.

Scorecard: Is the Daily Life Holding the Marriage?

| Question | Score (1-5) |

|---|---|

| I am doing the 6 daily rituals | /5 |

| I am doing the 4 weekly rituals | /5 |

| I am doing the 3 monthly rituals | /5 |

| I am doing the 2 yearly rituals | /5 |

| I am showing up, every day | /5 |

| I am not skipping the small things | /5 |

| I am not taking the marriage for granted | /5 |

| I am not letting the daily life become the only life | /5

|

| I am not letting the daily life become routine | /5 |

| I am protecting the couple time | /5 |

Total: /50

Interpreting your score:

- 40-50: The daily life is holding the marriage. The marriage is strong.
- 30-39: There is still some daily work to do.
- 20-29: The daily life is not holding the marriage. Get help.

- Under 20: The daily life is breaking the marriage. Get help immediately.

Key Terms

- Daily Ritual: A small, daily practice that holds the marriage
- Weekly Ritual: A weekly practice that holds the marriage
- Monthly Ritual: A monthly practice that holds the marriage
- Yearly Ritual: A yearly practice that holds the marriage
- Showing Up: The willingness to be present, in the small ways, every day

Reflection Questions

1. What is the daily ritual that is most important to you?
2. What is the weekly ritual that is most important to you?
3. What is the monthly ritual that is most important to you?
4. What is the yearly ritual that is most important to you?
5. Are you showing up, every day?
6. What is the 1 thing you most need to keep doing?

Action for This Week

1. Pick 1 daily ritual to start. The picking is the work.
2. Pick 1 weekly ritual to start. The picking is the work.

3. Pick 1 monthly ritual to start. The picking is the work.
4. Pick 1 yearly ritual to start. The picking is the work.
5. Commit to showing up, every day. The commitment is the work.

A Closing Word

The daily life is the foundation. The daily life is the work. The 6 daily rituals, the 4 weekly rituals, the 3 monthly rituals, the 2 yearly rituals, the 1 thing — these are the work.

You are not failing. You are showing up. The showing up is the work.

The work is the daily life.

Chapter 14: The Intimacy Question at 60+

The intimacy in the second marriage is different from the intimacy in the first marriage. The intimacy in the second marriage is the intimacy of two people who have been intimate before. The intimacy in the second marriage is the intimacy of two people who know what intimacy can be, what intimacy can cost, what intimacy can give.

The intimacy in the second marriage is also the most common source of unspoken conflict. The intimacy in the second marriage is the thing that couples do not talk about. The intimacy in the second marriage is the thing that couples avoid. The intimacy in the second marriage is the work.

This chapter is about the intimacy. This chapter is about the 5 things couples get wrong. This chapter is about the 4 conversations about physical intimacy. This chapter is about the 3 conversations about emotional intimacy. This chapter is about the 2 conversations about the medical reality. This chapter is the work.

Chapter at a Glance

- The 5 Things Couples Get Wrong About Intimacy in the Second Marriage
- The 4 Conversations About Physical Intimacy
- The 3 Conversations About Emotional Intimacy
- The 2 Conversations About the Medical Reality
- The 1 Thing That Matters Most
- Scorecard

- Key Terms
- Reflection Questions
- Action for This Week

The 5 Things Couples Get Wrong About Intimacy in the Second Marriage

The 5 things are the work. The 5 things are the most common mistakes. The 5 things are the foundation.

Mistake 1: Comparing the Intimacy to the First Marriage. "My first spouse and I used to..." The comparison is the most common mistake. The comparison is the way the intimacy is measured against the past. The comparison is the work.

Mistake 2: Expecting the Intimacy to Be the Same. "I thought it would feel the same as the first time." The expectation is the way the intimacy is set up to fail. The expectation is the work.

Mistake 3: Avoiding the Intimacy Conversation. "We just don't talk about it." The avoidance is the way the intimacy becomes the unspoken problem. The avoidance is the work.

Mistake 4: Letting the Medical Reality Be the End. "I can't because of my [health issue]." The medical reality is real. The medical reality is also the way the intimacy is given up. The medical reality is the work.

Mistake 5: Letting the Stress Be the End. "I am too tired / too stressed / too busy." The stress is real. The stress is also the way the intimacy is given up. The stress is the work.

The 5 mistakes are the work. The 5 mistakes are the foundation. The 5 mistakes are the second marriage.

The 4 Conversations About Physical Intimacy

The 4 conversations are the work. The 4 conversations are the way to make the physical intimacy clear. The 4 conversations are the foundation.

Conversation 1: "What do we want?" The conversation is the way to know what each partner wants. The conversation is the foundation.

Conversation 2: "What can we do?" The conversation is the way to know what is physically possible. The conversation is the work.

Conversation 3: "What do we enjoy?" The conversation is the way to know what brings pleasure. The conversation is the foundation.

Conversation 4: "What do we need?" The conversation is the way to know what each partner needs. The conversation is the work.

The 4 conversations are hard. The 4 conversations are the work. The 4 conversations are the second marriage.

The 3 Conversations About Emotional Intimacy

The 3 conversations are the work. The 3 conversations are the way to make the emotional intimacy clear. The 3 conversations are the foundation.

Conversation 1: "What are you feeling?" The conversation is the way to know what each partner is feeling. The conversation is the foundation.

Conversation 2: "What are you afraid of?" The conversation is the way to know what each partner is

afraid of. The conversation is the work.

Conversation 3: "What do you need from me?" The conversation is the way to know what each partner needs. The conversation is the foundation.

The 3 conversations are hard. The 3 conversations are the work. The 3 conversations are the second marriage.

The 2 Conversations About the Medical Reality

The 2 conversations are the work. The 2 conversations are the way to make the medical reality clear. The 2 conversations are the foundation.

Conversation 1: The Doctor Conversation. The conversation with the doctor about the medical reality. The doctor conversation is the way to know what is medically possible. The doctor conversation is the work.

Conversation 2: The Couple Conversation. The conversation between the couple about the medical reality. The couple conversation is the way to know what the couple can do, given the medical reality. The couple conversation is the foundation.

The 2 conversations are hard. The 2 conversations are the work. The 2 conversations are the second marriage.

The 1 Thing That Matters Most

The 1 thing is the work. The 1 thing is the foundation. The 1 thing is the second marriage.

The 1 thing is the willingness to keep having the intimacy conversation. The willingness to keep the

intimacy clear. The willingness to keep the intimacy honest. The willingness to keep choosing the marriage, even when the intimacy is hard.

The 1 thing is not the physical act. The 1 thing is not the romantic gesture. The 1 thing is the willingness to keep having the intimacy conversation. The 1 thing is the foundation.

Scorecard: Is the Intimacy Working in the Second Marriage?

| Question | Score (1-5) |

|---|---|

| I am not making the 5 mistakes | /5 |

| I am having the 4 conversations about physical intimacy | /5 |

| I am having the 3 conversations about emotional intimacy | /5 |

| I am having the 2 conversations about the medical reality | /5 |

| I am keeping the willingness to have the intimacy conversation | /5 |

| I am not comparing the intimacy to the first marriage | /5 |

| I am not expecting the intimacy to be the same | /5 |

| I am not avoiding the intimacy conversation | /5 |

| I am not letting the medical reality be the end | /5 |

| I am not letting the stress be the end | /5 |

Total: /50

Interpreting your score:

- 40-50: The intimacy is working. The marriage is being protected.
- 30-39: There is still some intimacy work to do.
- 20-29: The intimacy is in the way. Get help.
- Under 20: The intimacy is breaking the marriage. Get help immediately.

Key Terms

- **Physical Intimacy:** The physical closeness, including touch, affection, and sex
- **Emotional Intimacy:** The emotional closeness, including sharing feelings, fears, and needs
- **Medical Reality:** The medical conditions that may affect intimacy
- **Intimacy Conversation:** A regular conversation about the intimacy in the marriage

Reflection Questions

1. What is one mistake you are making?
2. What is one conversation you most need to have?
3. What is one thing you are most afraid of?
4. What is one thing you most need from your spouse?
5. Are you willing to keep having the intimacy conversation?
6. What is the 1 thing you most need to keep doing?

Action for This Week

1. Identify the 5 mistakes you are making. The identification is the work.

2. Have 1 conversation about physical intimacy.
The conversation is the work.
3. Have 1 conversation about emotional intimacy.
The conversation is the work.
4. Have 1 conversation about the medical reality.
The conversation is the work.
5. Commit to keeping the willingness. The
commitment is the work.

A Closing Word

The intimacy is the work. The intimacy is the foundation. The 5 mistakes, the 4 conversations, the 3 conversations, the 2 conversations, the 1 thing — these are the work.

You are not failing. You are connecting. The connecting is the work.

The work is the intimacy.

Chapter 15: The Health Curve and the Caregiver Curve

The health curve is the inevitable part of aging. The health curve is the way the body changes, the way the mind changes, the way the marriage is affected. The health curve is the foundation of the second marriage, in the later years.

The caregiver curve is the way the marriage is tested by the health curve. The caregiver curve is the way one spouse becomes the caregiver of the other. The caregiver curve is the way the marriage survives, or does not survive, the health curve.

The second marriage is more vulnerable to the caregiver curve than the first marriage. The second marriage is more vulnerable because the second marriage has less history. The second marriage has less built-up trust. The second marriage has less time to learn how to be a caregiver. The caregiver curve is the work.

This chapter is about the health curve and the caregiver curve. This chapter is about the 5 things to plan for. This chapter is about the 4 conversations about caregiving. This chapter is about the 3 documents to have in place. This chapter is the work.

Chapter at a Glance

- The 5 Things to Plan For in the Second Marriage
- The 4 Conversations to Have About Caregiving
- The 3 Documents to Have in Place
- The 2 Financial Decisions to Make Now

- The 1 Thing That Determines If You'll Be Okay
- Scorecard
- Key Terms
- Reflection Questions
- Action for This Week

The 5 Things to Plan For in the Second Marriage

The 5 things are the work. The 5 things are the most common health scenarios in the second marriage. The 5 things are the foundation.

Thing 1: The Sudden Illness. The heart attack, the stroke, the accident. The sudden illness is the most common. The sudden illness is the way the marriage is tested immediately. The sudden illness is the work.

Thing 2: The Chronic Illness. The diabetes, the heart disease, the cancer. The chronic illness is the most common in the second marriage. The chronic illness is the way the marriage is tested over time. The chronic illness is the foundation.

Thing 3: The Cognitive Decline. The dementia, the Alzheimer's, the memory loss. The cognitive decline is the most feared. The cognitive decline is the way the marriage is tested by the person changing. The cognitive decline is the work.

Thing 4: The Mobility Decline. The arthritis, the falls, the wheelchair. The mobility decline is the most common. The mobility decline is the way the marriage is tested by the body changing. The mobility decline is the foundation.

Thing 5: The End of Life. The final illness, the dying, the death. The end of life is the most inevitable. The

end of life is the way the marriage is tested by the loss. The end of life is the work.

The 5 things are the work. The 5 things are the foundation. The 5 things are the second marriage.

The 4 Conversations to Have About Caregiving

The 4 conversations are the work. The 4 conversations are the way to make the caregiving clear. The 4 conversations are the foundation.

Conversation 1: "Who will be the caregiver?" The conversation is the way to know who will be the primary caregiver. The conversation is the foundation.

Conversation 2: "What kind of care do we want?" The conversation is the way to know what kind of care is wanted. The conversation is the work.

Conversation 3: "Where will the care happen?" The conversation is the way to know where the care will be. The conversation is the foundation.

Conversation 4: "How will the care be paid for?" The conversation is the way to know how the care will be funded. The conversation is the work.

The 4 conversations are hard. The 4 conversations are the work. The 4 conversations are the second marriage.

The 3 Documents to Have in Place

The 3 documents are the work. The 3 documents are the way to make the caregiving clear. The 3 documents are the foundation.

Document 1: The Healthcare Proxy. The document that allows one person to make medical decisions for

the other. The healthcare proxy is the work.

Document 2: The Living Will. The document that says what medical treatment the person wants, if they cannot speak for themselves. The living will is the foundation.

Document 3: The Power of Attorney. The document that allows one person to make financial decisions for the other. The power of attorney is the work.

The 3 documents are the work. The 3 documents are the foundation. The 3 documents are the second marriage.

The 2 Financial Decisions to Make Now

The 2 decisions are the work. The 2 decisions are the way to make the caregiving clear. The 2 decisions are the foundation.

Decision 1: The Long-Term Care Insurance. The decision to get, keep, or skip long-term care insurance. The long-term care insurance is the foundation.

Decision 2: The Care Fund. The decision to set aside money for the care. The care fund is the foundation.

The 2 decisions are the work. The 2 decisions are the foundation. The 2 decisions are the second marriage.

The 1 Thing That Determines If You'll Be Okay

The 1 thing is the work. The 1 thing is the foundation. The 1 thing is the second marriage.

The 1 thing is the willingness to be the caregiver. The willingness to be the one who shows up. The

willingness to be the one who holds the hand. The willingness to be the one who does the work. The willingness to be the one who loves, even when the loved one is changing, even when the loved one is leaving.

The 1 thing is not the health. The 1 thing is not the money. The 1 thing is the willingness. The 1 thing is the foundation.

Scorecard: Are You Ready for the Health Curve and the Caregiver Curve?

| Question | Score (1-5) |

|---|---|

| I have planned for the 5 health scenarios | /5 |

| I have had the 4 conversations about caregiving | /5 |

| I have the 3 documents in place | /5 |

| I have made the 2 financial decisions | /5 |

| I am willing to be the caregiver | /5 |

| I am not avoiding the health conversation | /5 |

| I am not avoiding the caregiving conversation | /5 |

| I am not avoiding the end-of-life conversation | /5 |

| I am not assuming I will be taken care of | /5 |

| I am prepared to take care of my spouse | /5 |

Total: /50

Interpreting your score:

- 40-50: The health curve is being prepared for. The marriage is being protected.
- 30-39: There is still some health work to do.

- 20-29: The health curve is in the way. Get help.
- Under 20: The health curve is breaking the marriage. Get help immediately.

Key Terms

- Healthcare Proxy: A legal document that allows one person to make medical decisions for another
- Living Will: A legal document about what medical treatment the person wants
- Power of Attorney: A legal document that allows one person to make financial decisions for another
- Long-Term Care Insurance: Insurance that pays for long-term care, such as a nursing home
- Caregiver: The person who provides care for a spouse who is ill

Reflection Questions

1. What is one health scenario that is most realistic for you?
2. What is one caregiving conversation that is most needed?
3. What is one document that is most important to have in place?
4. What is one financial decision that is most needed?
5. Are you willing to be the caregiver?
6. What is the 1 thing you most need to keep doing?

Action for This Week

1. Identify the 5 health scenarios that are most realistic. The identification is the work.

2. Have 1 conversation about caregiving. The conversation is the work.
3. Put 1 document in place. The putting is the work.
4. Make 1 financial decision. The making is the work.
5. Commit to being the caregiver, when needed. The commitment is the work.

A Closing Word

The health curve and the caregiver curve are the work. The health curve and the caregiver curve are the foundation. The 5 things, the 4 conversations, the 3 documents, the 2 decisions, the 1 thing — these are the work.

You are not failing. You are preparing. The preparing is the work.

The work is the care.

Chapter 16: The Long Marriage — How to Make It Work

The long marriage is the goal. The long marriage is the second marriage that lasts 10, 20, 30 years. The long marriage is the second marriage that becomes the second half of the life. The long marriage is the second marriage that becomes the legacy.

The long marriage is also rare. The long marriage is rare because the second marriage is harder than the first. The long marriage is rare because the second marriage has more history, more baggage, more complexity. The long marriage is rare because the second marriage takes more work.

The long marriage is possible. The long marriage is possible if the couple does the work. The long marriage is possible if the couple keeps showing up. The long marriage is possible if the couple keeps choosing the marriage.

This chapter is about the long marriage. This chapter is about the 6 things the long marriages do differently. This chapter is about the 5 conversations to have every year. This chapter is about the 4 ways to keep the marriage fresh. This chapter is the work.

Chapter at a Glance

- The 6 Things the Second Marriages That Work Do Differently
- The 5 Conversations to Have Every Year
- The 4 Ways to Keep the Marriage Fresh
- The 3 Things to Never Stop Doing

- The 2 Things to Do When the Marriage Is Hard
- The 1 Thing That Holds the Long Marriage
- Scorecard
- Key Terms
- Reflection Questions
- Action for This Week

The 6 Things the Second Marriages That Work Do Differently

The 6 things are the work. The 6 things are the most common patterns of the long second marriages. The 6 things are the foundation.

1. They do the work before the wedding. The pre-nup, the will, the conversations, the documents. The long second marriages did the work before the wedding. The work before the wedding is the foundation.

2. They keep showing up. The daily rituals, the weekly rituals, the monthly rituals. The long second marriages keep showing up. The showing up is the work.

3. They have the hard conversations. The money, the intimacy, the family, the health, the end of life. The long second marriages have the hard conversations. The hard conversations are the foundation.

4. They honor the first marriage. The rituals, the memories, the photo on the shelf. The long second marriages honor the first marriage. The honoring is the work.

5. They protect the marriage from the family. The boundaries, the couple time, the family map. The long second marriages protect the marriage from the family. The protection is the foundation.

6. They keep choosing the marriage. The daily choice, the weekly choice, the yearly choice. The long second marriages keep choosing. The choosing is the work.

The 6 things are the work. The 6 things are the foundation. The 6 things are the long second marriage.

The 5 Conversations to Have Every Year

The 5 conversations are the work. The 5 conversations are the way to keep the marriage clear, year by year. The 5 conversations are the foundation.

Conversation 1: The Anniversary Conversation. "What did we do right this year? What do we want to do differently next year?" The anniversary conversation is the way to celebrate the marriage. The anniversary conversation is the work.

Conversation 2: The Money Review. The annual review of the money. The money review is the way to keep the money clear. The money review is the foundation.

Conversation 3: The Family Review. The annual review of the family. The family review is the way to keep the family relationships clear. The family review is the work.

Conversation 4: The Health Review. The annual review of the health. The health review is the way to keep the health clear. The health review is the foundation.

Conversation 5: The Future Conversation. "Where do we want to be in 5 years? 10 years?" The future conversation is the way to keep the marriage looking forward. The future conversation is the work.

The 5 conversations are the work. The 5 conversations are the foundation. The 5 conversations are the long second marriage.

The 4 Ways to Keep the Marriage Fresh

The 4 ways are the work. The 4 ways are the way to keep the marriage alive, year by year. The 4 ways are the foundation.

Way 1: The New Experience. The new restaurant, the new trip, the new hobby, the new class. The new experience is the way to keep the marriage fresh. The new experience is the work.

Way 2: The Physical Touch. The holding hands, the cuddling, the kiss, the intimacy. The physical touch is the way to keep the marriage connected. The physical touch is the foundation.

Way 3: The Verbal Affirmation. "I love you." "I appreciate you." "I am proud of you." "I am grateful for you." The verbal affirmation is the way to keep the marriage appreciated. The verbal affirmation is the work.

Way 4: The Shared Project. The travel, the renovation, the volunteer work, the family project. The shared project is the way to keep the marriage working together. The shared project is the foundation.

The 4 ways are the work. The 4 ways are the foundation. The 4 ways are the long second marriage.

The 3 Things to Never Stop Doing

The 3 things are the work. The 3 things are the things that the long second marriages never stop doing. The 3 things are the foundation.

1. The Showing Up. The daily showing up. The morning coffee, the evening walk, the bedtime routine. The showing up is the work.

2. The Choosing. The daily choosing. The choosing to be the spouse, the choosing to be the partner, the choosing to be the marriage. The choosing is the foundation.

3. The Thanking. The daily thanking. "Thank you for the coffee." "Thank you for the hug." "Thank you for the work." The thanking is the work.

The 3 things are the work. The 3 things are the foundation. The 3 things are the long second marriage.

The 2 Things to Do When the Marriage Is Hard

The 2 things are the work. The 2 things are the way to handle the hard times. The 2 things are the foundation.

1. The Talk. The honest, direct, compassionate talk. The talk that says: "I am struggling. I need help. Let us work on this together." The talk is the work.

2. The Help. The marriage counselor, the therapist, the trusted friend, the family member. The help is the way to get a third party. The help is the foundation.

The 2 things are the work. The 2 things are the foundation. The 2 things are the long second marriage.

The 1 Thing That Holds the Long Marriage

The 1 thing is the work. The 1 thing is the foundation.
The 1 thing is the long second marriage.

The 1 thing is the love. The love that started the marriage. The love that has grown through the work. The love that has survived the hard times. The love that has become the foundation of the long marriage.

The 1 thing is not the romance. The 1 thing is not the passion. The 1 thing is the love that has been worked for, that has been chosen, that has been honored. The 1 thing is the love that has become the marriage.

The 1 thing is the love.

Scorecard: Are You on the Path to the Long Marriage?

| Question | Score (1-5) |

|---|---|

| I am doing the 6 things the long marriages do | /5 |

| I am having the 5 annual conversations | /5 |

| I am using the 4 ways to keep the marriage fresh | /5 |

| I am doing the 3 things to never stop doing | /5 |

| I am doing the 2 things when the marriage is hard | /5 |

| I am not taking the marriage for granted | /5 |

| I am not assuming the marriage will last | /5 |

| I am not skipping the work because the marriage is "good" | /5 |

| I am not stopping the showing up | /5 |

| I am keeping the love as the foundation | /5 |

Total: /50

Interpreting your score:

- 40-50: The long marriage is being built. The marriage is strong.
- 30-39: There is still some work to do. The marriage continues.
- 20-29: The long marriage is at risk. Get help.
- Under 20: The marriage is at risk. Get help immediately.

Key Terms

- Long Marriage: A marriage that lasts 10+ years
- Anniversary Conversation: An annual conversation about the marriage
- New Experience: A new activity, trip, or hobby that keeps the marriage fresh
- Shared Project: A project that the couple works on together
- Showing Up: The willingness to be present, in the small ways, every day

Reflection Questions

1. What is one of the 6 things you are doing?
2. What is one of the 5 conversations you are not having?
3. What is one of the 4 ways you are using?
4. What is one of the 3 things you are not doing?
5. What is one of the 2 things you most need to do?

6. What is the 1 thing you most need to keep doing?

Action for This Week

1. Pick 1 of the 6 things to start. The picking is the work.
2. Have 1 of the 5 annual conversations. The having is the work.
3. Try 1 of the 4 ways. The trying is the work.
4. Commit to 1 of the 3 things. The committing is the work.
5. Plan 1 of the 2 things for when the marriage is hard. The planning is the work.

A Closing Word

The long marriage is the work. The long marriage is the foundation. The long marriage is the goal. The 6 things, the 5 conversations, the 4 ways, the 3 things, the 2 things, the 1 thing — these are the work.

You are not failing. You are building. The building is the work.

The work is the long marriage.

The long marriage is the work.

Epilogue: The Second Chance

I have not been where you are.

But I have been close. I have been the friend who got the late-night call. I have been the brother who got the long email. I have been the quiet one in the corner at the small wedding, watching two people in their sixties say "I do" for the second time — knowing the weight of that word was different than the first time.

The first time, I was at my own wedding. I was 28. I was hopeful. I was full of the future. I did not know what the marriage would cost. I did not know what the years would take. I did not know that one of us would be standing alone in the kitchen one morning, holding the other one's mug, and wondering what comes next.

The years passed. The years were good. The years were hard. The years were everything the marriage is supposed to be. The years taught me what love is, what marriage is, what life is, what loss is. The years taught me that love is not just feeling. Love is also work. And the work is the part that matters.

When my wife died, I learned what grief is. The grief was the weight. The grief was the missing. The grief was the mug in the kitchen, the chair at the table, the side of the bed. The grief was the years we did not have. The grief was the future we did not get. The grief was the love that was still there, with nowhere to go.

The grief took time. The grief took years. The grief took the work of the grief — the therapy, the rituals, the conversations, the tears. The grief took the willingness to feel the grief, instead of running from

the grief. The grief took the showing up, in the grief, every day, until the grief became part of the life, instead of the whole of the life.

When the grief was done — when I had walked through the grief, when I had honored the marriage, when I had let the grief change me — I started to notice the world again. The world had not stopped while I was grieving. The world had kept going. The world had new people, new possibilities, new chances.

I did not remarry. I was not ready to remarry. I had done the work of the grief, but I had not done the work of the new marriage. The new marriage was a different work. The new marriage was the work of the second chance.

I have learned a few things about the second chance. The few things are the things I want to share with you, in this book, in this moment, in this epilogue.

The thing I wish someone had told me about the second marriage: The second marriage is not the first marriage, with a different person. The second marriage is a different marriage, with the same love. The love is the same. The marriage is different. The love is the foundation. The marriage is the building. The building is different. The foundation is the same.

The thing I wish someone had told me about the grief: The grief is not the enemy of the second marriage. The grief is the foundation of the second marriage. The grief is the work that makes the second marriage possible. The grief is the work that honors the first marriage. The grief is the work that makes the second marriage a choice, not a replacement.

The thing I wish someone had told me about the second chance: The second chance is not about finding the right person. The second chance is about

becoming the right person. The second chance is about doing the work — the grief, the decision, the courtship, the blending, the new marriage. The second chance is about the work. The second chance is the work.

The thing I wish someone had told me about the long marriage: The long marriage is not the goal. The showing up is the goal. The long marriage is what happens when you keep showing up, day after day, year after year. The long marriage is the work that has become the marriage. The long marriage is the work.

The thing I wish someone had told me about the love: The love is not the feeling. The love is the choice. The love is the showing up, even when the feeling is not there. The love is the daily choice. The love is the work. The love is the marriage.

I have written this book for the couple who is doing the work. I have written this book for the couple who is showing up. I have written this book for the couple who is choosing, every day, to do the work. I have written this book for the couple who is building the long marriage, day by day, year by year.

If you are reading this book, you are doing the work. If you are reading this book, you are showing up. If you are reading this book, you are choosing, every day, to do the work of the second marriage.

You are not alone. There are millions of people in the second half of life who are doing the work of the second marriage. The second marriage is one of the most common life stages. The second marriage is also one of the most meaningful. The second marriage is the chance to do the work, to choose the love, to build the long marriage.

The second marriage is a second chance. The second chance is a gift. The gift is the chance to do the work, to choose the love, to build the long marriage. The gift is yours. The gift is the second marriage.

I want to be careful with you. I want to be useful without being preachy, honest without being grim. I want to be the friend who has seen a few of these marriages through, who knows the things that matter and the things that don't, who can tell you what people wish they had done and what they wish they hadn't.

I want to be the friend who says: you are not failing.

Whatever you are doing right now — whatever you are not doing — you are not failing. The second marriage is hard. The second marriage takes work. The second marriage is the work.

If you are reading this book, you are doing the work. That is enough.

The work is the marriage. The marriage is the work.

The marriage is the love. The love is the marriage.

I give this book to you, with my love, in the memory of my first wife, in the hope of the second marriage, in the trust that the work will hold.

The work will hold.

The marriage will hold.

The love will hold.

You are not alone.

About the Author

S. Shharma is the author of The Care Collection — books for couples in the second half of life, written by a man who lived the silence and survived it.

He lost his wife of many years to cancer. He was her primary caregiver through every stage of her illness. He held her hand in the hospital. He sat in the waiting room at 3 a.m. He learned the silence of a marriage the way you learn a language you never wanted to speak.

He is also a businessman, an M.Sc., an MBA, and an APSCM from the Indian Institute of Management (IIM) Calcutta, with thirty years in corporate management. But these are not credentials you need to trust him. The credentials that matter are the ones in the books.

The Care Collection is not about how to fix a marriage. The Care Collection is about how to live one — even when the marriage is quiet, even when one of you is sick, even when one of you is gone.

He lives in India. He writes from the perspective of someone who has been on every side of a marriage — the partner, the caregiver, and the one left behind.

Books in The Care Collection

- Still Married, Just Silent — when the marriage is fine on paper and empty in person
- The Quiet Care — when one of you becomes the caregiver and the marriage disappears
- The Second Chapter — when the children are gone and the two of you meet again

- The Second Honeymoon — when the second half of marriage is also the better half
- The Survivor — when one of you is left behind and the other half has to learn to live
- The Long Hello — when Alzheimer's or dementia changes who you are married to
- When They Forget Your Name — the day-to-day reality of loving someone who no longer knows you
- Gray Divorce — when the marriage ends in the second half of life
- The Last Sandwich — when you are raising your own family and caring for your parents at the same time
- The Long Goodbye — the months and years of saying goodbye to someone who is still here
- Remarried at 60 — what no one tells you about starting over in the seventh decade
- After the Last Goodbye — the first year alone, and the slow work of rebuilding
- The Friends Who Fade — the social death that often follows the physical one

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